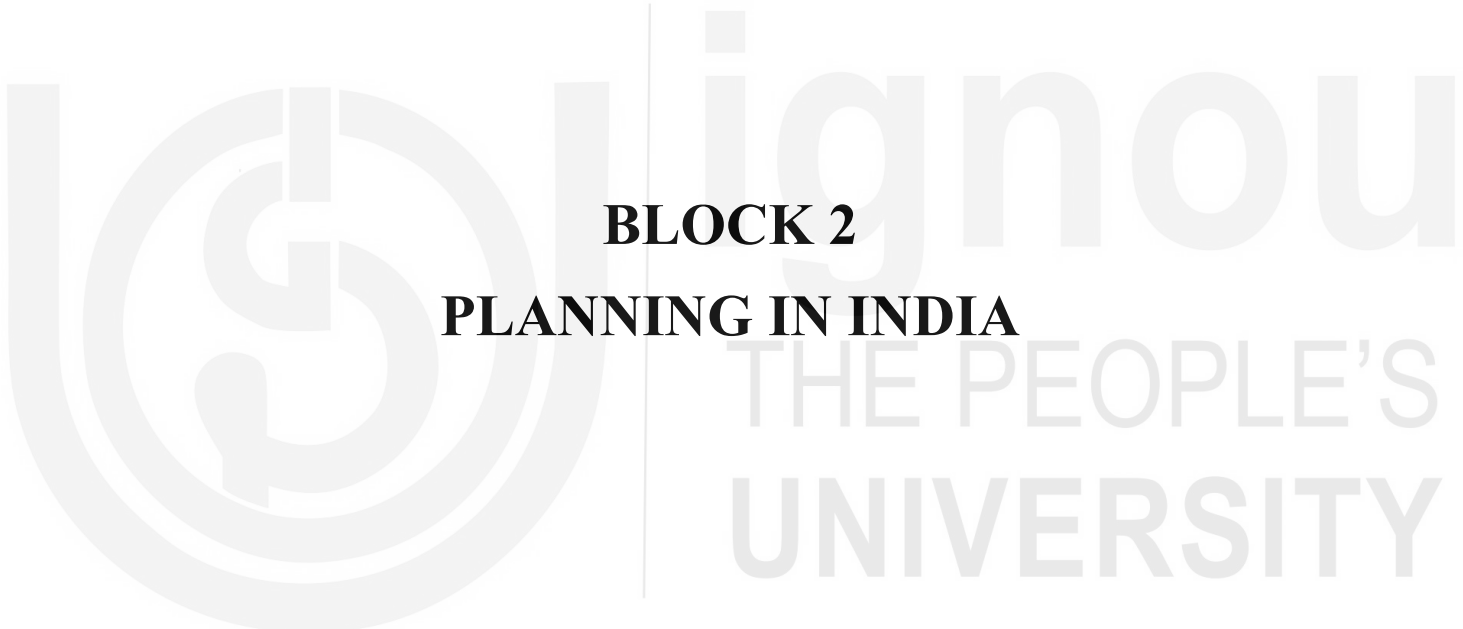


The background of the page features a large, light grey watermark of the Open University logo. The logo consists of a stylized 'U' and 'O' forming a circular emblem, with the text 'Open University' and 'THE PEOPLE'S UNIVERSITY' integrated into the design.

BLOCK 2

PLANNING IN INDIA



UNIT 5 MULTI-LEVEL PLANNING

Structure

- 5.0 Aims and Objectives
- 5.1 Introduction
- 5.2 Decentralized and Multi-Level Planning
- 5.3 Multi Level Structure of Planning
- 5.4 Some Issues
- 5.5 Let Us Sum Up
- 5.6 Key Words
- 5.7 Suggested Readings

5.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit aims to provide you with an understanding of multi-level planning, which is important for the development of any planning system. At the end of the unit, you should be able to:

- State the strengths and weaknesses of decentralized planning;
- Indicate the factors to be considered in multi-level planning; and
- Describe the levels of planning.

5.1 INTRODUCTION

Course MRD-101 should have given you an idea of the socio-economic structure of rural India and the working of rural development administration. Course MRD-102 would have given you a comprehensive picture of the variety of development programmes that have been undertaken by the Government. In the preceding two units of this block, you studied development planning and its process in India. We made a brief mention there of the role that structures below the State level play in the overall planning system. This unit examines the planning structures at different levels.

Decentralized planning for rural development should be viewed in relation to various levels and agencies of development. The linkage between decentralized planning for rural development and the total system of planning has to be understood. This understanding will be essential for more meaningful designing of projects, managing development projects during implementation and monitoring of such projects.

5.2 DECENTRALIZED AND MULTI LEVEL PLANNING

Decentralized planning is defined as that form of planning where the task of formulating, adopting, executing and supervising the plan is dispersed, rather than entrusted to a central authority. In decentralized planning, the regional and local bodies are given greater freedom to formulate, adopt and implement the plan. Why do we need decentralized planning? Centralization or decentralization are not by themselves good or bad. Both these methods of planning derive their character from the political and administrative structure, political philosophy, past practice and public pressure. Centralized planning may also not be able to keep in view the socio-economic, climatic and ecological diversities in the country, as is the case in India. Decentralized planning makes the plans and programmes more suitable to local conditions. In several developing countries, following the model adopted in socialist countries, in the initial phases, a somewhat centralized planning approach was adopted. However, a mix of planning exercises through devolution of such functions at different levels is important in most situations. Planning in India is decentralized to some extent since the States have definite responsibilities. In fact, serious consideration has been given to make district planning an effective entity. Most commentators have been of the view that we need to work more and more towards decentralized planning.

The stimulus for consideration of multi-level planning arises from recognition of the need for decentralized planning. Strictly speaking, a plea for decentralization implies that some functions, which can be more efficiently performed at lower levels in the hierarchy, are currently being performed at higher levels. Logically, therefore, any plea for decentralization implies a hypothesis about the appropriate functions to be performed at different levels. The approach of multi-level planning involves capturing the logical hypothesis in the interest of optimal functioning of a system. In the context of planning for social change, such appropriateness of both levels and functions will have to be determined in the socio-political context.

The need for decentralized planning provides the justification for planning at multiple levels. The former provides the logic for the existence of the latter. Decentralization of the planning process makes planning more meaningful, more democratic and more responsive to the needs of those for whom planning is meant. However, planning at multiple levels has to be integrated. This is the primary objective and the main challenge of multi-level planning.

In brief, therefore, multi-level planning may be defined as the utilization of a number of well-defined area levels and agency levels, performing well understood functions, operating in the same territory and people inhabiting such territory.

Let us note the factors in multi-level planning. Multi-level planning implies identification of levels at which planning functions are assigned and the respective areas of responsibilities. It includes determination of criteria on the basis of which such allocation of functions are made and integrating the planning structures at different levels into the planning system. Multi-level planning, thus, leads to decentralization of planning functions.

Merits and Demerits of Decentralized Planning

Under centralized planning, decision making at the centralized level and direction from a single level is possible. However, there are high costs of obtaining information, loss of time, difficulties in applying concepts uniformly to all situations, problems of distortions in transmitting decisions for implementations etc., which reduce the effectiveness of centralized planning. In other words, from a purely cost-effective angle of decision making, it is better to have a number of agency levels in a semi-hierarchical fashion, entrusted with decision-making powers. Further, the socio-political compulsions may require that decision-making powers are distributed to more than one level for the same area. Similarly, decisions can be made at different levels by the same agency or by different agencies.

- 1) Decentralized planning gives greater freedom to the regional bodies and local enterprises, as compared to centralized planning.
- 2) Decentralized planning represents, in a way, planning from below and spreads out authority – political and economic – to lower and horizontal levels. It, thus, promotes popular participation and recognizes the value of local and sub-regional factors, and the needs of a pluralistic society.
- 3) Centralized planning is affected by bureaucratic functioning and growth of red tapism and, therefore, there is loss in the efficiency of management. Decentralized planning helps to a large extent in overcoming this problem.
- 4) Centralized planning may result in the centralization of powers. Moreover, individual initiative and enterprise may be adversely affected by such a system. Decentralized planning helps to overcome these possibilities.
- 5) In centralized planning, the formulators are often not aware of ground realities, and often standardized programmes and schemes are prepared, which may not be suitable at all places. In decentralized planning, the plans are more realistic.

Decentralized planning has its own handicaps. These are:

- Decentralized planning, sometimes, does not reflect national priorities, which is possible in centralized planning. It is, therefore, not able to strengthen the nationalist forces or fight divisive forces.

- Decentralized planning also suffers from rampant corruption which leads to the wastage of resources. Greater accountability is needed at each level of planning.
- In decentralized planning, the administrative and political structures at the lower levels may act as constraints to change and development. This may be through cornering the benefits of development or by covertly or overtly opposing alterations, which will empower other groups. The disadvantaged may be too weak to stake their claims.
- Technical capabilities in planning are often limited at the lower levels. On balance, however, an optimum mix of centralized and decentralized planning seems desirable. For instance, areas of national and international importance like core sector industries, communication, etc. may need centralized planning, while areas of agriculture, rural development, water supply, etc. may benefit from decentralized planning. By and large, areas, which are widely dispersed, dissimilar in resources, and have problems, which are locality specific, need decentralized planning. Rural development is an area, which meets this description and needs a decentralized system of planning.

Decentralized Planning in India

The idea of decentralized planning and “Planning from Below” have been familiar to planners for a long time. There have been several efforts at decentralized planning in many States. Maharashtra’s experiment with District Planning Boards in 1972 has been a subject of many discussions. The states of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and West Bengal attempted decentralized planning in 1980s. In the initial years of planning, certain hard choices had to be made between the needs of national security, unity and growth on the one hand, and redistribution of growth on the other. Since the former took precedence over the latter, decision making functions remained centralized and vertical upto the State level. The design of political and developmental set up in the country, therefore, did not seriously consider decentralization at the sub-state level.

The Second and the Third Plans had mentioned local horizontal plans, preparation of State plans based on district, block and village plans and devolution of responsibilities to Panchayati Raj institutions. However, these ideas did not really take off due to the fact that the overall framework of centralized planning continued and also because of the inadequacy of planning capabilities at such levels. In the Fourth Plan period, the need for strengthening the planning machinery at different levels was recognized. Decentralized planning came into the forefront only with the advent of the Fifth Plan when a number of Special Area Programmes were undertaken with specialized agencies for their implementation.

During the Sixth Plan, the procedures for effective functional, financial and administrative decentralization upto the district level were outlined to the

States. However, decentralized planning, to be effective, would need building up capabilities assiduously, evolving of right procedures and suitable structures, and changes in technical and administrative areas including attitudinal changes. The process of encouraging assimilation of new ideas needs to be taken up through learning by doing.

During the Seventh Plan, a High Level Committee to Review the Existing Administrative Arrangements for Rural Development and Poverty Alleviation Programmes (CAARD) was set up under the Chairmanship of Shri G.V.K. Rao. The report of the CAARD Committee suggested devolution of administrative powers in a re-structured administrative set up for decentralized planning.

The fact remains that the Indian experience with decentralized planning is mixed. The Working Group Report of 1984 noted, “(There has been) a certain disconcentration of administration from the state to the district levels, with the planning and decision making functions mostly confined to the higher echelons of administration and with the local population only marginally, if at all, associated with the activities that concern their development and welfare”. In many States the District Development Boards or Councils exist, but they have little or no autonomy in local decision making, although admittedly, the extent of decentralization would vary from State to State.

The 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments of 1992 have made specific provisions for the preparation and implementation of plans by Panchayats and municipalities and for setting up District Planning Committees. Recently Niti Aayog, the apex body for planning in India is stressing the need to focus on backward districts which have the potential to help in the national development. Niti Aayog has termed these district as the aspirational districts.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Use the space provided below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

1) Define decentralized planning.

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2) List three merits of decentralized planning.

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5.3 MULTI LEVEL STRUCTURE OF PLANNING

The important feature of planning in India is that it operates in a democratic framework through a federal system, involving concurrent planning at the national and State levels.

The federal nature of India's Constitution demands planning at least at two levels, i.e., Union and States (economic and social planning) being in the Concurrent List of the Constitution. However, in view of the mixed economy resulting from a pluralistic socio-economic environment and the large size of some States, planning at sub-State and micro-levels is also required. Thus, multi-level planning in India has to be viewed in terms of activities at different area and agency levels extending well beyond the union and State framework.

A multi-level structure of planning for the country, based on the politico-administrative structure, is shown in Table 5.1 below:

Table 5.1: The Levels and Types of Planning

Planning Level	Political/ Administrative Territorial Equivalent	Abstract Territorial Equivalent	Planning Concept
Macro-level (National Plan)	Nation	-	Central Planning/Policy Planning/Sectoral Planning
Meso-Level (Sub- national plan or State plan)	State	State/Resource/Region/River Valley/ Metropolitan Region	State Plan/Sectoral Budgetary Planning/ Regional Planning/Town & Country Planning
Micro-Level (Decentralized Plan)	District	Area	District Planning Area Development
	Block	Sub-area/micro- region Local Level	Micro-Level Planning/Block level planning
	Village		Village plan and planning for target group

The territorial equivalents of macro and meso-level planning are clearly defined as nation and States, respectively. However, the term micro-level planning will continue to remain vague until the actual levels of planning are clearly defined. In the Indian context, the abstract territorial equivalent of micro-level is the district. However, in the Integrated Rural Development Programme (IRDP), currently under implementation, the block, which is the lowest unit of development, administratively, has been considered as the unit of planning at the micro-level.

The macro or national plan mainly provides the broad framework of national objectives and resource allocation pattern to achieve these objectives. It includes the State plans and indicates the sectoral allocation of resources. The micro-level or district and lower level plans are mainly based on local priorities and needs. The outlays for these are found from the State plans. Thus, as we move down to the lower levels of planning, local needs and priorities draw more attention. In a country like India, micro-level planning would, therefore, be more rural oriented.

In considering planning for rural development in the context of multi-level planning, the following important considerations have to be kept in view:

- At each level, there may be a number of agencies taking decisions, which appear to be independent of each other, but are, in fact, an expression of cognizance of the inter-relationship of their respective functions. For instance, laying a railway line would be the function of the Union Government, a bus taking passengers to the railway line may be run by a State level public enterprise and the road on which the bus travels may include the national highways, State highways, or village roads under the control of panchayats, etc. Thus, decentralized planning or local planning will have to constantly interact with other planning agencies at higher levels, particularly in designing physical or locational aspects.

Apart from interaction among the governmental levels, there will be need for interaction with other organisations, such as cooperatives, farmer's associations, voluntary organisations and other agencies.

- The decentralized planning unit will also interact with adjacent decentralized units either on its own or through a higher level. Thus, if there is an anicut on a rivulet constructed by one village, there may be no water left for the village down below. Similarly, industry in one village can cause pollution in the next village.
- It is difficult to draw a rigid line between rural and non-rural areas. Even in rural areas, there are villages of different sizes. There is also the phenomenon of rural-urban continuum caused by interdependence, continuity and flow between rural and urban societies. Many villages depend on urban areas for services. Inputs are often purchased by the rural people from urban markets and output may also have to be sold to

urban markets. Similarly, some educational and health facilities, repairing facilities, etc. are available only in towns. It is not possible, therefore, to plan for all facilities in all villages. Thus, decentralized planning in a rural development context cannot confine itself only to rural areas, but should be able to interact with planning in urban areas also.

Consistency Factors

The focus of development planning is on transforming the rural areas, keeping the social, economic, technological and cultural horizons in mind. Therefore, the primary characteristic of any plan must be consistency among the planning exercises undertaken at different levels. This means that a plan undertaken at one level should be in harmony with exercises undertaken at other levels.

The plan at lower levels should have the freedom to choose among national objectives for the following reasons:

- i) **Feasibility or Relevance:** Depending on the feasibility or relevance of the national objective to the block, a plan may or may not correspond or give the same weightage to national plan objectives. For instance, the national plan objective of self-reliance translated at the block level would imply that outflow of goods and services from the block to the rest of the country increase to a level at which these can pay for the inflow of goods and services. Since the block is a part, even if a smaller part of the national economy, self-reliance in this sense is, therefore, not feasible.
- ii) **Freedom to Fix Priorities:** Since the specific situation at the local level is quite different from the national scene, a block plan may even give different weightage to national priorities in its scheme of priorities. For example, let us consider the case of a national programme designed to generate self-employment and income in rural areas. It is obvious that the actual priority areas chosen in the local are as will vary according to their needs and feasibility. For instance, it will not be possible to generate employment/income through poultry farming or dairy projects in all places across the country.
- iii) **Target Fixing:** A block drawing upon the available resources and its own experiences should have the freedom to fix its own targets, depending upon their feasibility. Now, what is a target? It is a quantified expression derived from the objective and indicates the time frame for its achievement. When fixing a target, the quantum of resources and relevant institutional and organisational arrangements, manpower, feasibility, etc. have to be taken into consideration.

A target can be used to assess the magnitude of the task that lies ahead for achieving the stated objectives. As an illustration, consider the objective of removing poverty at the block level. Assume that 70 per cent

of the population in the block is poor and the per capita consumption expenditure among this section is much below aspecified minimum. Now, while assessing the efforts in fulfilling the block plan objective for removing poverty, you discover that only about 30 per cent of the poor could be effectively served by suitable employment and income earning opportunity. Such being the case, you would have to assess the magnitude of the task that lies ahead of you. Hence, effort will be needed to effectively serve the needs of the remaining 40 per cent of poor.

- iv) **Information Base:** The information base is a very crucial component and has to be developed at different levels. This has to be developed as an integrated system that the information flows help to strengthen and reinforce the inter-linkages, both horizontally and vertically. The designing of an information base requires professional expertise as well as data gathering, processing and transmission facilities.
- v) **Relationship among Plan Objectives:** There may be either a complementary or a competitive relationship between plan objectives. A complementary relation is ensured if a plan, which contributes positively to one objective, makes a positive contribution to the second as well, or at least, does not make a negative contribution. A competitive relationship, on the other hand, means that a positive contribution to one objective may (in some cases at least) lead to a negative contribution to the other.

There exists, for example, a complementary relation between employment generation and poverty removal; also between poverty removal and better distribution of income and assets. In contrast, there are, in some cases, conflicts between higher income growth and its better distribution (at least in the short run) and also between higher income growth and higher employment.

Since conflicts between objectives occur typically at the block and lower levels, the nature of the relationship among plan objectives should be identified. Then, the various instruments and institutions available – public investments, subsidies, credit facilities, levies, fees, public and cooperative forms of property ownership and other such organisations – should be used in such a way that the block plan reinforces complementarity among objectives and does not unduly sacrifice one objective infavour of another, whenever there is a conflict. For example, a programme designed to boost agricultural output may result in generating higher incomes – but not necessarily for agricultural labourers. Thus, in this case, the objective of generating higher output may conflict with the objective of achieving more equitable growth. In such a situation, special measures may have to be taken to achieve the second objective as well.

5.4 SOME ISSUES

The process of multi-level planning involves identification of the area levels, activities, and agencies. Let us briefly consider these.

Identification of Area Levels

The need for decentralization in the planning process is widely recognized. However, what the levels ought to be and how the various levels are to be integrated into a cohesive planning structure, is a matter of debate.

A major problem, widely recognized, is one that relates to the activities that should appropriately be undertaken at each area level. Over time, there has been tension between the Union and the State governments over both political, financial and economic matters. Center-State relations have been a matter of intense debate in our country. The States are particularly incensed with the matter relating to financial powers being concentrated heavily in the hands of the Union Government. This, according to them, has severely handicapped them, particularly in the area of financial independence, to manage their own affairs. The Administrative Reforms Commission, the different Finance Commissions and the Sarkaria Commission have submitted comprehensive reports on Centre-State relations in different spheres. However, the issue raised from time to time, particularly by states that are governed by a political party different from that at the Center, has not been resolved.

In determining appropriate area levels, there is need to take into account not only planning requirements in terms of techniques and processes, but also social, political and administrative structures. At the time of Independence, there was need to integrate a large number of technically sovereign units, of varying sizes and differing structures, into one coherent entity. States were carved out within a formal federal structure. 'Districts' within the State, as basic units, were kept intact wherever viable, with occasional changes. Villages were consolidated into Community Development Blocks in the early fifties on a nation-wide basis. Formalizing and functionalising the units peacefully was a great achievement of the fifties.

There are intermediate tiers between area levels also with a view to ensure coordination. Thus, 'Zonal Council' (not quite active) was envisaged for a group of States. In some of the larger States, groups of districts are under a Division for administrative coordination. In many States, regulatory administration is carried out by a *taluk* (which has been redefined to be coterminous with a development block) and these are often grouped under a Sub-division for administrative purposes.

The units below the State are entirely within the jurisdiction of the State concerned. In the mid-eighties, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka modified the block level and introduced mandals as units, analogous to, but smaller than a block.

Identification of Activities

A ticklish problem, however, relates to the issues or activities that should appropriately be undertaken at each area level. The division of powers and responsibilities between the Union and the States is enshrined in the Constitution. Over the period, however, as in the case of most federations, there have been tensions between the Union and States both on political and on financial – economic plane.

An important issue of discussion for long has been whether the division of powers and functions between State and sub-State level should be nationally determined or left to individual States to decide. The need to introduce Constitutional provisions to ensure continuity and authenticity to such arrangements, particularly in regard to elections for bodies at sub-state levels, has also been under discussion. The 1992 Amendments says that “Panchayat-shall continue for five years”... (Article 243E). It also provides for State Election Commission for “the conduct ofall elections to the Panchayats”(Article 243K).

A variety of approaches have been advanced in regard to differentiation of activities based on micro and macro aspects, degree or linkages in developmental programmes, potentialities of development, and efficiency factors in execution of projects and processes.

The official committees (including the Hanumantha Rao Working Group of 1984 on district planning), however, focussed on the techniques and procedures of formulating, implementing and monitoring district plans, and replicating (and adopting) comprehensive planning process, coupled with detailed planning for projects. Realizing the intricacies involved, the Government of India had decided to attempt model district plans (in 1988).

The Ninth Plan makes it clear that “district development plans would have to be prepared – through the institution of District Planning Committee” set up by the states under the 73rd and 74th Amendments. “Gram Sabha would list out priorities and a list in the selection of beneficiaries for various programme and schemes....village level plans... would be incorporated in the intermediate plans and finally merged into a district plan”. The Plan also suggests that the District Planning Committee should not only consolidate plans from below but should take decisions of the district within the given resource potential and identified needs and constraints.

Identification of Planning Agencies

The area levels have significance for purposes of policy with reference to the functional agencies, their powers and inter-relations, both vertical and horizontal (i.e. across the area levels and within the same area level). For convenience, these agencies could be categorized into political decision making bodies; the planning organisations; the staff agencies (ministries); the line agencies (the government executive departments); the public enterprises;

and the cooperative structure. In addition, there are a number of specialized agencies, especially at district level, established under the Societies Registration Act in the form of government committees for integrated planning. A number of private bodies, such as associations of farmers, traders and industrialists may also be involved in the process.

Thus, in a given geographical area, there are various levels of government, such as Centre, State and District and several agencies at each level functioning in the same area. The relationship in each category could vary in degree from superior subordinate, equal, to semi-independent in nature.

The way the agencies are structured at each area level in terms of representation to area-levels, and the superior subordinate, semi-equal or equal nature of relationship in access to resources and powers of decision making, constitutes the core of multilevel planning. When the framework at sub-State level is varying and unclear, the functioning in reality can be very much at variance with formal structures (leading to accusation of hypocrisy or real centralization in the guise of decentralization).

Check Your Progress 2

Note: a) Use the space provided below for your answers.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

- 1) Name some Commissions, which have deliberated on Centre-State relations in different spheres.

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- 2) State the areas where there have been increasing friction between the Centre and States.

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5.5 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we saw the linkage between decentralized planning for rural development and the total system of planning so essential for a meaningful designing of projects.

Multi-level planning, we stated, requires a decentralized planning system. Decentralization implies assumptions about the appropriate functions to be performed at different levels. Multi-level planning operationalises these assumptions in the interest of optimal functioning of the system. In the context of planning for social change, appropriateness of both levels and functions is determined in the socio-political context. The socio-political compulsions may require that decision-making powers are distributed among more than one levels for the same area. Therefore, multi-level planning implies existence of several well defined area levels and agency levels. A ticklish problem, we saw, relates to the issues of activities that should appropriately be undertaken at each area level. We also noted the various consistency factors in multi-level planning.

5.6 KEY WORDS

Anicut : Dam on a river built for irrigation purposes.

Decentralization : Delegation of decision-making powers to different levels in a hierarchy.

Mixed economy : An economy characterized by the co-existence of government and private sector activities.

5.7 SUGGESTED READINGS

Alagh, Y.K. (1973), "District Planning for Integral Development" *Journal of the Lal Bahadur Academy of Administration*, Mussoorie.

Redd Y. Venugopal (1979), *Multi-Level Planning in India*, Vikas, New Delhi.

UNIT 6 DISTRICT LEVEL PLANNING

Structure

6.0 Aims and Objectives

6.1 Introduction and Background

- 6.1.1 National Rural Employment Guarantee Programme (NREGP)
- 6.1.2 Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY)
- 6.1.3 Indira Awas Yojana (IAY)
- 6.1.4 National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) Including Annapurna
- 6.1.5 National Rural Health Mission (NRHM)
- 6.1.6 Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS)
- 6.1.7 The Accelerated Rural Water Supply Programme (ARWSP)
- 6.1.8 Mid-Day Meal (MDM) Scheme
- 6.1.9 Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA)
- 6.1.10 Accelerated Irrigation Benefits Programme (AIBP)
- 6.1.11 Rajiv Gandhi Grameen Vidyutikaran Yojana (RGGVY)

6.2 Participative District Level Planning

- 6.2.1 A Cross-functional Team Transformed a Vertical Process into a Horizontal Operation
- 6.2.2 More IT-enabled Participative Planning: Using IT to Support Participatory Planning

6.3 Data Management for District level Planning

- 6.3.1 Intermediate Panchayat Level Resource Centre
- 6.3.2 Urban Databases
- 6.3.3 Linking the 2010 Census with Local Governments

6.4 Institutional and Other Support for District Planning Committees

- 6.4.1 Gram Sabha Level: An Effort to Raise Awareness
- 6.4.2 The Abilities of Members of Local Government Standing Committees are being Developed
- 6.4.3 Capacity-building for Elected Officials, Including Sarpanches, Mukhiyas, and Adhyakshas
- 6.4.4 Building the Capacity of Local Government Officials

6.5 Let Us Sum Up

6.6 Keywords

6.7 References and Suggested Readings

6.8 Check Your Progress – Possible Answers

6.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit will help you to understand:

- The importance of Micro Level Planning in India;
- Historical background of District Level Planning;

- Importance of Decentralized Planning in India; and
- Application of IT and ICT for Micro Level Planning.

6.1 INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND

Villages have always been the backbone of Indian culture and social environment. Since ancient times, villages have influenced the majority of cultural and social practices surrounding them. The expansion and growth of these small administrative units is still an important task. After independence, the government emphasized strongly on the growth of villages, with decentralized planning being an integral part of the First Five-Year Plan (1951-1956). The Plan proposed that the planning process should be carried out at both the state and district levels. In each district, a District Development Council (DDC) was established under these arrangements to prepare plans based on a village-level participatory process to varying degrees. In 1957, the Government appointed Balwant Rai Mehta Committee which recommended constitution of elected statutory local bodies with its required resources, power and authority along with a decentralised administrative system operating under its control. Accordingly, the Panchayati Raj System was introduced in India.

Since then the process of decentralisation in the planning and developmental activities was continued. The first Administrative Reforms Commission (1967), which was initially Chaired by Shri Morarji R Desai, and later on by Shri K. Hunmanthaiya) emphasized the importance of district-level planning, with a focus on regional differences in growth patterns. In 1969, India's Planning Commission released one of the first district-level planning guidelines. These guidelines aided many states in developing district-level plans and putting them into action. The aim of district-level planning is to make the most of the natural resources available in the region. Again in 1977, M.L. Dantewala working group recommended specific guidelines for the introduction of block-level planning. After that Ashok Mehta Committee has also submitted its report on Panchayati Raj in 1978. Moreover, the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, finally presented its Report on Decentralisation of Development Planning and its implementation in the states in 1983. Finally, in 1984, the Group on District Planning submitted its report and this was considered as the basis of proposals on decentralised planning under the Seventh Plan.

District-level planning is essentially area-based planning that will aid state-level plans and, finally, contribute to national planning in India. District-level preparation can also be useful for obtaining detailed information about a district's finances, challenges, and opportunities. In the past, services were created in such a way that the needs of each district were addressed. District level planning is somewhat similar to integrated area planning, which states that district level planning is a sub-state entity for decision-making that comes under multi-level planning. However, over the years district planning

programmes faded as local planning exercises were not linked to the annual planning process in most states, despite a few excellent examples. Furthermore, as a part of the district's planning, these programmes did not include urban planning processes. Panchayats were also not able to function as autonomous planning units within their functional domain due to a lack of financial capital.

From the late 1960s to the mid-1980s, there was a movement towards greater administrative centralization. Panchayats had been superseded in most states by the late 1960s due to a lack of concerted political and administrative support. The development of Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSSs), which were mostly enforced by line offices, caused the district planning process to virtually collapse. Several attempts to stem the tide (The Dantwala Committee, The G.V.K. Rao Committee) were largely ineffective. Vertical planning was preferred due to the poor existence of local self-governance structures, as well as the growth and proliferation of sectoral departments and parastatal bodies, which obscured information about the resources available for a decentralized planning process in districts.

Table 2.1: Plans for District Level Planning

Year	Item	Ideas and Concepts
First Plan 1951-56	Community Development Blocks	To divide the planning process into four levels: national, state, district, and local community.
Second Plan 1956-61	District Development Councils	Village plans are being drawn up, and the public is being invited to participate in planning through a democratic process.
1957	Balwant Rai Mehta Committee	Institutions for village, block, and district panchayats have been established.
1967	1 st Administrative Reforms Commission	Resources to be provided/local variations to be accommodated, and a well-thought-out plan for the area.
1969	Planning Commission	Formulated guidelines; described the concept of a district plan and the methodology for drafting one in the context of annual, medium-term, and long-term plans.
1978	Prof. M.L. Dantwala	Village and district-level planning will be linked by block-level planning.
1983-84	CSS/Reserve Bank of India	Strengthen the district plan and the credit plan for the district.
1984	Hanumantha Rao Committee	Functions, powers, and finances are decentralized; District planning bodies

		and district planning cells are being established.
1985	G.V.K. Rao Committee	Rural development is managed by the District Panchayat, which is in charge of all development programmes.

Shri V. Ramachandran, the Minister of Panchayati Raj, chaired an expert group on the eve of the Eleventh Five Year Plan's preparation in 2005 to research and make recommendations. Among the other things, the expert group proposed formulation of District and Sub-District Plans at all Panchayat levels with the goal of delivering basic minimum needs to people at the grass-root level. Both the Commission and the expert group approved the report submitted by the Planning Ministry and the Ministry of Panchayati Raj. In a circular dated August 25, 2006, the Planning Commission released comprehensive recommendations for district plans in the Eleventh Five-Year Plan.

The Eleventh Five-Year Plan emphasized the importance of involving a large number of elected local government officials in the planning, implementation and oversight of essential public services for an inclusive growth process. The section of the plan dealt with governance reforms that are needed to place local governments at the heart of local planning, implementation, and oversight. The plan also requires each district to create a District Development Plan that includes plans for its future development within those areas, their sectoral allocations for various schemes, as well as constituent urban and rural areas. It also suggests the need for three interconnected plans: (i) long-term perspective or structure plans (20-25 years), (ii) short-term integrated infrastructure development plans coterminous with the National Five-Year Plan, and (iii) plans for specific projects and schemes. Furthermore, institutional reform, which is critical for district planning, has begun in the states. Most states have enacted legislation for the formation of DPCs (District Planning Committees) in accordance with Article 243ZD. Significant resources, on the other hand, are flowing from the Centre to the states via CSSs and Additional Central Assistance (ACA) to address socio-economic backwardness, which includes infrastructure development and service delivery at the local level. The Central Annual Plan has grown in size from year to year, reaching more than Rs. 2,40,000 crores in 2008-09. In rural areas 13 major CSSs have been implemented, which are as follows:

- National Rural Employment Guarantee Programme (NREGP)
- Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY)
- Indira Awas Yojana (IAY)
- National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) including Annapurna
- National Rural Health Mission (NRHM)
- Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS)

- Accelerated Rural Water Supply Programme (ARWSP)
- Mid-Day Meals Programme (MDM)
- Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA)
- Accelerated Irrigation Benefits Programme (AIBP)
- Rajiv Gandhi Grameen Vidyutikaran Yojana (RGGVY).

6.1.1 National Rural Employment Guarantee Programme (NREGP)

The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MNREGA) was notified by the Indian government in September 2005, and it went into effect on February 2, 2006. It is one of the largest work guarantee programmes in the world. The main feature of this Programme is to improve living standard by providing 100 days of guaranteed wage employment to every household whose adult members volunteer to do unskilled manual labour every financial year to ensure the livelihood security of households in rural areas of the state. Unlike earlier employment guarantee schemes, the act aims at addressing the causes of chronic poverty through a rights-based framework in which at least one-third of beneficiaries have to be women. Also wages must be paid according to the statutory minimum wages specified for agricultural labourers in the state under the Minimum Wages Act, 1948.

There is an emphasis on strengthening the process of decentralisation by giving a significant role in Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) in planning and implementing these works. The act mandates Gram sabhas to recommend the works that are to be undertaken and at least 50% of the works must be executed by them.

6.1.2 Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY)

The government launched the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY), as part of a poverty-reduction strategy in which India plans to connect unconnected habitations. In order to ensure sustainable management of the rural road network, Indian government is working to establish high, consistent technical and management standards while also facilitating policy development and planning at the state level.

According to the most recent figures released by state governments as part of survey conducted as part of the PMGSY programme to identify core network, approximately 1.67 lakh unconnected households are eligible for coverage. This will necessitate the construction of approximately 3.71 million kilometres of new road network and upgradation of approximately 3.68 million kilometres of existing roads.

6.1.3 Indira Awas Yojana (IAY)

Indira Awaas Yojana, which was previously a part of Jawahar Rozgar Yojana (JRY), became a separate scheme in 1997-1998. Its goal is to build free

houses for Scheduled Castes/ Scheduled Tribes members, Non-SC/ST rural poor living below the poverty line, as well as freed bonded labourers in rural areas. Beneficiaries are chosen from a list of people living Below the Poverty Line (BPL) that has been approved by the Gram Sabha. During each fiscal year, at least 60% of the total IAY allocation should be used to build or upgrade rural housing units for SC/ST BPL families. Non-SC/ST BPL rural households are eligible for up to 40% of the allocation. Physically and mentally challenged people should be allocated 3% of the above categories. The Indian government has also requested that 15% of the beneficiaries come from minorities. This scheme is funded by both Centre and State Government in the ratio of 75:25 and for North Eastern States this ratio is 90:10 and 100% for UTs.

6.1.4 National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) Including Annapurna

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) is an important step towards realizing the Directive Principles of Articles 41 and 42 of the Constitution, which recognize the concurrent responsibility of the Central and State Governments in this area. Article 41 of India's Constitution, in particular, directs the government to provide public assistance to citizens in the event of unemployment, old age, sickness, or disability, as well as other unjustified circumstances within the confines of poverty, economic development and capacity.

Presently NSAP comprises of five schemes, namely:

- 1) Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS).
- 2) Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS).
- 3) Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS).
- 4) National Family Benefit Scheme NFBS).
- 5) Annapurna

6.1.5 National Rural Health Mission (NRHM)

The Hon'ble Prime Minister launched the National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) on April 12, 2005, with the goal of providing accessible, affordable, and high-quality health care to the rural population, particularly vulnerable groups. The Union Cabinet approved the launch of the National Urban Health Mission (NUHM) as a Sub-mission of the overarching National Health Mission (NHM), with the National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) as the other Sub-mission of the National Health Mission, in a decision dated May 1, 2013.

The essence of NRHM is a health delivery system that functions independently, is community-owned and decentralized. The mission also aims to deliver a constant support to those who contribute to the social

determinants of health. Basic objectives to implement NRHM are:

- 1) Reduction in infant mortality rate and maternal mortality rate
- 2) Ensuring population stabilization
- 3) Prevention and control of communicable and non-communicable diseases
- 4) Upgrading AYUSH (Ayurvedic Yoga Unani Siddh and Homoeopath) for promotion of a healthy lifestyle.

6.1.6 Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS)

ICDS Scheme, which began on October 2, 1975, is one of the Government of India's flagship programmes with the largest and the most unique early childhood care centres and development programmes in the world. As a response to the challenge of providing pre-school non-formal education on the one hand, and breaking the vicious cycle of malnutrition, morbidity, reduced learning capacity, and mortality on the other hand, it is the most visible symbol of the country's commitment to its children and nursing mothers. Children aged 0-6 years, pregnant women, and lactating mothers are among the scheme's beneficiaries. The Scheme's goals are to:

- a) Improve the nutritional and health status of children aged 0 to 6 years;
- b) Lay the groundwork for a child's proper psychological, physical, and social development;
- c) Lower mortality rates, morbidity, malnutrition, and school dropout; and
- d) Ensure that policy and implementation are coordinated effectively across departments.

6.1.7 The Accelerated Rural Water Supply Programme (ARWSP)

The Government of India launched the Accelerated Rural Water Supply Programme (ARWSP) in 1972-73 to help states and union territories (UTs) speed up the coverage of drinking water supply. With the launch of the Technology Mission on Drinking Water and Related Water Management in 1986, the entire programme was given a Mission mode. In 1999, the Department of Drinking Water Supply was established to focus more on the Rural Water Supply Program. By March 2004, the National Agenda for Governance has set a goal of providing drinking water to all rural villages in the country. To meet this goal, the Accelerated Rural Water Supply Program (ARWSP) budget was increased significantly from Rs.1,715 crore in 1999-2000 to Rs. 2,900 crore in 2004-05. Water supply has been extended to the majority of the country's 14.22 lakh rural habitations as of December 31, 2003. Only 8,686 habitations classified as Not Covered habitations remain to be supplied with water.

In 2009 the National Rural Drinking Water Programme (NRDWP) was launched in by modifying the Accelerated Rural Water Supply Programme (ARWSP) and subsuming earlier sub-missions/schemes. The objective of the Programme is to provide safe and adequate water for drinking, cooking and other domestic needs to every rural person on a sustainable basis. It aims to cover all rural population in Arsenic/Fluoride affected habitations with clean drinking water on a sustainable basis by March 2021.

6.1.8 Mid-Day Meal (MDM) Scheme

The Midday Meal Scheme comes under the HRD Ministry's Department of School Education and Literacy. Launched in the year 1995 as a centrally sponsored scheme, it provides that every child within the age group of six to fourteen years studying in classes I to VIII who enrolls and attends the school, shall be provided hot cooked meal having nutritional standards of 450 calories and 12 gm of protein for primary (I- V class) and 700 calories and 20 gm protein for upper primary (VI-VIII class), free of charge every day except on school holidays.

The scheme covers all government and government aided schools and also Madarsa and Maqtabas supported under the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA). It is the world's largest school meal programme aimed to attain the goal of universalization of primary education.

6.1.9 Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA)

The Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA) is the Government of India's flagship programme for achieving Universalization of Elementary Education (UEE) in a timely manner, as mandated by the 86th amendment to the Indian Constitution, 2002, which makes free and compulsory education for children aged 6 to 14 years as a Fundamental Right. The programme aims to build new schools in areas where there are none, as well as to improve existing school infrastructure by providing additional classrooms, toilets, drinking water, maintenance grants, and school improvement grants.

6.1.10 Accelerated Irrigation Benefits Programme (AIBP)

The Accelerated Irrigation Benefits Programme (AIBP) was established by the Central Government in 1996-97 to provide central assistance to major/medium irrigation projects in the country, with the goal of accelerating the implementation of such projects that were beyond the States' resource capability or were nearing completion. Priority was given to the projects that began during the Pre-Fifth and Fifth Plan periods, as well as those that benefited Tribes and Drought-Affected Areas. AIBP became a part of PMKSY (Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana) after its launch in 2015-16. Since its inception, AIBP has approved funding for 297 irrigation and multi-purpose projects. 143 of these projects have been completed, while 5 have been foreclosed.

6.1.11 Rajiv Gandhi Grameen Vidyutikaran Yojana (RGGVY)

The Rural Electricity Infrastructure and Household Electrification Scheme, or Rajiv Gandhi Grameen Vidyutikaran Yojana (RGGVY), was launched in 2005 with the goal of providing electricity to all rural households. The scheme is 90% funded by the government and 10% by the Rural Electrification Corporation (REC). This programme is available to all rural households that fall below the poverty line.

Check Your Progress 1

Note:a) Use the space provided for your answers.

b) Check your answers with the possible answers provided at the end of this unit.

- 1) Explain the significance Eleventh Five-Year Plan with respect to district level planning in India.

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6.2 PARTICIPATIVE DISTRICT LEVEL PLANNING

We are at a critical juncture in which participatory decentralized planning is gaining attraction. Similarly, advances in Information and Communication Technology (ICT) have enabled the long-awaited vision of participatory planning to be effectively implemented on a national scale. The time has come to have a participatory planning process, led by local governments, in other words we can say that plans that are relevant to the local area can be prepared, with the help of local communities and governments. This alone will result in improved outcomes. Because participatory district planning is multifaceted, it necessitates following a well-organized sequence of steps in order to arrive at a useful plan. Important considerations include the difference between constitutional and legal frameworks, in which the legal framework will govern the participatory design process for rural and urban governments. The next most significant factor is the multiple levels of local government, which includes panchayats at the local level as well as envisioned by municipalities. So, there are numerous areas that need to be developed (health, education, nutrition, livelihoods, and so many others), a mix of various funding sources (central and state, as well as government-sponsored), along with a tangled departmental and programme apparatus with each having its own objectives.

6.2.1 A Cross-functional Team Transformed a Vertical Process into a Horizontal Operation

With increased specialization and sector-specific efforts, there has been a trend toward developing sector-specific plans. Thus, most of the terms are mentioned, such as the District Health Plan, the Water Quality Plan, and so on. Planning along these lines is unavoidable, but it is crucial that they change to a horizontal one in which jurisdictions, organisations, such as local governments, seeks to share the responsibility and improve resource utilisation. In the absence of it, only the district heads, not each planning entity, would have complete knowledge of a plan. The planning handbook aims to bring together the vertical planning process, which is critical for ensuring that sectoral expertise is effectively utilised, and the horizontal overall planning process, which is equally important for ensuring efficiency and accountability. A plethora of agencies has resulted in segmented, fragmented, and sub-optimal planning in the context of urban planning. Cities, for example, create a City Development Plan (CDP), a Land Use Plan or Master Plan (MP), a City Mobility Plan (CMP), and an Environment Plan (EP).

6.2.2 More IT-enabled Participative Planning: Using IT to Support Participatory Planning

There are several reasons for emphasizing the use of ICT tools to anchor and thus significantly improve the quality of decentralized planning right from the start. ICT accounts make capturing, integrating, and analysing baseline data much easier to support institutions. ICT allows decision-makers at all levels, from the DPC to Panchayats and municipalities, to Gram Sabhas, to see much more meaningful data. Great decision-making can be made easier through presentation of data, using maps, charts, and animation. ICT will allow better budgetary control, the recording, advancement, and finishing of selected projects, and implementation of plans. The key ingredient is ICT's potential to allow everyone to see the entire planning process, and to help bring a central planning ideal to fruition. Several IT-enabled decentralised planning initiatives are gaining attraction across the country. It is necessary to bring these currently disparate initiatives together in order to maximize efforts. They serve the ebb and flow of decentralized planning when used together.

A decentralised planning strategy will act as an integrated approach to meet all processes, from data collection to intervention, planning, and also will ensure the needs of each planning unit are met. While it is still important to create the conceptual framework and workflow to serve as a roadmap for the decentralised solution, it is equally critical that the solution be steered by the logic of the existing decentralised approach.

Check Your Progress 2

Note:a) Use the space provided for your answers.

b) Check your answers with the possible answers provided at the end of this unit.

1) Name few plans developed for district level planning.

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2) Explain IT-enabled participative planning?

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6.3 DATA MANAGEMENT FOR DISTRICT LEVEL PLANNING

Every strategy begins with a vision. This vision necessitates a solid empirical foundation, which can only be attained by collecting and analysing baseline data that is as well-established as the planning system itself. This exercise is known as the “stock-taking report” for the district and explained what goes into it. One of the most significant roadblocks to effective planning is a lack of primary and secondary data. Even when data is available, it is often unclassified, which restricts the scope of analysis. Local governments do not disaggregate it to the appropriate scale for planning purposes. In addition, it is frequently out of date. Each user agency has a tendency to collect data from scratch because there are no mandated single sources or agencies for reliable data supply. This is inefficient and inexpensive, and it will lead to database inconsistencies in the future.

The first step in automating data management is to categorize data so that it is easy to use and retrieve. If each item on which data must be collected is classified according to various “Keys“ or “Data headers,” it will be easier to organize, store, manage, retrieve, and use data. It will also allow for a high level of consistency in data collection, presentation, and comparison across jurisdictions. This classification can be used to create data management software that all users involved in the District Planning process can use. The data source isn’t always the best level, but it’s the only one available at the

time. With better awareness and technology, the data collection workflow should be aware of the possibility that the sources from which data is collected may change. Greater decentralisation would inevitably result in better data being available locally, as local institutions recognise the need for more information about themselves.

Instead of focusing too much on the ideal level of data collection, the Task Force recommends that a centralised focus on the collection of existing data on the Planning Commission's parameters be given at first. Data collection deadlines could be set later, as the decentralised planning system becomes more institutionalised. The value that Panchayats and municipalities can bring to the data collection process must be recognised by central and state departments and ministries. The next step would be to educate Panchayats and municipalities about the value of this data for both local and regional planning once a centralised drive of data collection from existing sources has been completed. Panchayats and municipalities should be encouraged to collect data on their own as a result.

6.3.1 Intermediate Panchayat Level Resource Centre

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation is laying the groundwork for a strategy to provide policymakers with reliable data. Data collection is linked to Panchayats in the new approach. According to the plan, a district statistics cell would be attached to the District Planning Committee. A Management Information System (MIS) is also required for use by local governments and line departments. The Ministry of Panchayati Raj's guidelines for the Backward Regions Grant Fund (BRGF) have already envisaged an Intermediate Panchayat-level resource centre as a common support system for Panchayats. The Block Resource Centres could be used by other key central ministries as a data collection and coordination hub for their respective sectors. In other words, the Resource Centre would collect data on behalf of the Panchayats for other line departments at the block and sub-block levels. The resource centre should then expand to include other services such as data collection its use and analysis for use training of local government employees. The Resource Center provides direct access to information from external assistance agencies, non-governmental organisations, social activists and people, as well as studies conducted by academic and research groups, banks, hospitals and schools, public authorities and other community platforms.

6.3.2 Urban Databases

Similarly, each urban unit should have its own data centre, similar to the National Urban Data Bank and indicators under the NUIS (National Urban Information System) Scheme, which was launched in 2005-06 to establish a comprehensive information system in urban local bodies for planning, development, and management. The scheme is divided into two parts: (i) The Urban Space Information System (USIS); and (ii) The National Urban Data

Bank and The Indicators (NUDB & I). The NUDB & I is an efficient foundation for the Urban Resource Center. It includes the piloting of utility mapping as well as the development of attribute and spatial databases for different levels of urban planning and decision support. A GIS database for 150 cities is being developed on a scale of 1:10000 and 1:2000 under the scheme.

6.3.3 Linking the 2010 Census with Local Governments

If census data is made available to local governments, the quality of local planning will improve dramatically. Decadal censuses, on the other hand, have prolonged revenue village enumerations. As needed, each revenue village is subdivided into enumerator blocks. At the request of the states, the Registrar General of India (RGI) was able to complete the Panchayat correlation revenue village in 11 states. However, this has been determined to be impractical in the remaining states, as the dwellings that make up the income village may be divided among the different Panchayats. To avoid such a situation, States must ensure that all village incomes are fully connected to one of the Panchayats. Enumerator blocks established by the RGI to carry out the census listing should also be located within the same Panchayat. If the state takes care of this, the 2010 census list can be handled by local governments from the outset.

Check Your Progress 3

Note:a) Use the space provided for your answers.

b) Check your answers with the possible answers provided at the end of this unit.

1) Explain the importance of Block Resource Centers?

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2) Role of urban databases for micro level planning?

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6.4 INSTITUTIONAL AND OTHER SUPPORT FOR DISTRICT PLANNING COMMITTEES

A Constitutional Article (Part IX, Article 243D) directs districts covered by these sections to form District Planning Committees (DPCs) to prepare a Developmental Strategy (DS) which consists of an expansion plan prepared by Panchayats (local-level planning bodies) and Municipalities (local government) and consolidates the strategies (planned growth in the areas) for these entities to the district level. The District Planning Committee is required to consider issues of common interest between Panchayats and municipalities in the preparation of a Drought development plan, such as spatial planning, water sharing and other physical and natural resources, integrated infrastructure development and environmental conservation. District Planning Committees, on the other hand, have yet to come into their own in most states in the 15 years since the 74th Amendment (1992) was enacted. As of now, five states have not established District Planning Committees as required by the constitution. In addition, in countries where district planning committees have been set up, the roles they often play differ from those expected by the Constitution. One of the main reasons that the District Planning Committees have been unable to prepare Drought development plans for the entire district is that they are typically unprepared to lead the district planning process. As a result, District Planning Committees are best described as committees that meet on occasion to hurriedly endorse a 'plan' or 'plans' prepared by departmental officials without proper appreciation. For the District Planning Committees to function effectively, their precise roles must be clarified by formal government orders. The following activities would be included in the activity mapping of the District Planning Committees: providing overall leadership to the district planning process.

- a) To conduct a vision exercise for the district
- b) Establishing district priorities based on local-government consensus.
- c) During the consolidation process, review plans from local governments and development departments to ensure that they address the district's overall vision and are free of overlapping and duplication.
- d) With the assistance of the National Bank for Agricultural and Rural Development (NABARD), play a key role in the preparation of the district's Potential Linked Credit Plan (PLCP)
- e) Supervise the district development plan's participatory planning process to ensure that timelines are met.

6.4.1 Gram Sabha Level: An Effort to Raise Awareness

Some of the tools proposed for raising awareness at the Gram Sabha include:

- Short films depicting the benefits of planned development will be broadcast or screened prior to the Gram Sabha meeting.
- Folk media (such as theatre and songs) are being used to raise awareness about development issues.
- Increased focus on community organisations such as Self-Help Groups (SHGs) and Primary Cooperatives, Local Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), Societies, and Forest Committees.

6.4.2 The Abilities of Members of Local Government Standing Committees are being Developed

- Raising committee members' awareness through print and electronic media, as well as district-level training programs.
- Developing and disseminating specific guidelines to local governments outlining their responsibilities.
- Keeping Standing Committees up to date on local government schemes and budgets, as well as the planning and budgeting process.
- Line department field functionaries provide constant updates on government circulars and other implementation instructions.

6.4.3 Capacity-building for Elected Officials, Including Sarpanches, Mukhiyas, and Adhyakshas

- The goal is to keep Panchayat leaders independent for making decisions about development on their own.
- The importance of decentralised planning could be taught to the Sarpanch and Panchas.
- Through training programmes, increased interaction with experts on the district planning process can be held.
- Increasing public awareness of the significance of socio-economic indicators, particularly those relating to the primary and social sectors.
- There is a need for a thorough and critical understanding of how basic services departments, such as health, education, livelihoods, and welfare, operate, and how their investments contribute to (or do not contribute to) the balanced development of the area.
- The links between infrastructure development and social sector improvement, as well as how infrastructure can act as a catalyst for faster growth.
- Understanding of line department reporting formats and who to contact if there are any questions or clarifications.
- How to use the RTI Act and how to respond to information requests.

- Comprehending the financial devolution system's fundamentals, such as how state budgets are approved, how they are communicated to Panchayats, and the role and responsibilities of Finance Commissions.
- Comprehending the importance of obtaining internal resources from both tax and non-tax sources, as well as the methods for doing so.

6.4.4 Building the Capacity of Local Government Officials

- An overview of decentralisation, the participatory district planning process, and their roles in the process. Officers may also invite elected officials to a few of these training camps so that they can interact with them in a less formal setting.
- Improving local government secretaries' ability to organise Gram Sabha and ward committee meetings, prepare and distribute minutes, and prepare action-taken reports (e.g., GP secretaries, BDOs of Intermediate Panchayats, and Chief Officers of Municipalities).

Check Your Progress 4

Note:a) Use the space provided for your answers.

- b) Check your answers with the possible answers provided at the end of this unit.

- 1) Briefly explain the effects of capacity building programme for officials?

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- 2) List some of the major activities of District Level Planning committee?

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6.5 LET US SUM UP

Villages have influenced our cultures since ancient times. Planning for the smaller administrative unit has been a concern of government since independence. Various efforts have been made to undertake the process of decentralization planning. The First Five Year Plan (1951-56) was the first-time the idea of decentralized planning was proposed. From there on different

committees have been set up to ensure the formulation of micro level planning process in the country. The Administrative Reforms Commission concentrated on district-level planning with the aim to reduce regional differences. In 1969, the Planning Commission released the first district planning recommendations, which prompted many states to develop district plans. The aim of district-level planning is to make the most of the natural resources available in the region. Planning can also be useful for obtaining detailed information about a district's finances, challenges, and opportunities. Vertical planning was preferred due to the poor existence of local self-governance structures. The development of Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS) caused the district planning process to virtually collapse. Thus there is still a lot of work to be done to decentralise planning in India.

6.6 KEYWORDS

Administrative Reforms: Administrative Reforms Commission (1967) emphasized the **Commission (1967)** importance of district-level planning, with an emphasis on local differences in growth patterns

Pradhan Mantri Gram: As part of a poverty-reduction strategy, India plans to connect **Sadak Yojana** unconnected habitations.

National Urban Data: The NUDB & I is a good foundation for the Urban Resource **Bank and the Indicators** Center. It includes the piloting of utility mapping as well as the development of attribute and spatial databases for different levels of urban planning and decision support.

Developmental Strategy: It consists of an expansion plan prepared by Panchayats (local-level planning bodies) and Municipalities (local government) and consolidates the strategies (planned growth in the areas) for these entities to the district level.

6.7 REFERENCE AND SUGGESTED READINGS

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6.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS – POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The Eleventh Five-Year Plan emphasised the importance of involving a large number of elected local government officials in the planning, implementation, and oversight of essential public services for the inclusiveness of our growth process.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) District Health Plan, the Water Quality Plan planning along these lines is unavoidable, but it is crucial that they change to a horizontal one in which jurisdictions, organisations, such as local governments, seek to share responsibility and improve resource utilization.
- 2) ICT solutions make capturing, integrating, and analysing baseline data much easier for support institutions. ICT allows decision-makers at all levels, from the DPC to Panchayats and municipalities, to Gram Sabhas, to see much more meaningful data. Great decision-making can be made easier through presentation of data, using maps, charts, and animation. ICT will allow better budgetary control, the recording, advancement, and finishing of selected projects, and implementation of plans.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) The Block Resource Centres could be used by other key central ministries as a data collection and coordination hub for their respective sectors. In other words, the Resource Centre would collect data on behalf of the Panchayats for other line departments at the block and sub-block levels. The resource centre should then expand to include other services such as data collection, analysis, and data collection and use training for local government employees.
- 2) National Urban Data Bank and indicators under the NUIS Scheme, which was launched in 2005-06 to establish a comprehensive information system in urban local bodies for planning, development, and management. The scheme is divided into two parts: The Urban Space Information System (USIS); and (ii) the National Urban Data Bank and the Indicators (NUDB & I).

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) The goal is to keep Panchayat leaders from making decisions about development on their own, the importance of decentralized planning could be taught to the Sarpanch and Panches, through training programmes, increased interaction with experts on the district planning process, increasing public awareness of the significance of socio-economic indicators, particularly those relating to the primary and social sectors.

- 2) To conduct a vision exercise for the district, establishing district priorities based on local-government consensus, during the consolidation process, review plans from local governments and development departments to ensure that they address the district's overall vision and are free of overlapping and duplication, with the assistance of the National Bank for Agricultural and Rural Development, play a key role in the preparation of the district's Potential Linked Credit Plan (PLCP) (NABARD), supervise the district development plan's participatory planning process to ensure that timelines are met.



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UNIT 7 BLOCK LEVEL PLANNING

Structure

- 7.0 Aims and Objectives
- 7.1 Introduction
- 7.2 Concept, Meaning and Scope of Block Level Planning
- 7.3 Benefits of Block Level Planning
- 7.4 Objectives of Block Level Planning
- 7.5 Progress in Block Level Planning in India
- 7.6 Block Planning for Beneficiary Oriented Programmes
- 7.7 Preparation of Block Development Plan
 - 7.7.1 Process for Block Development Plan
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 - 7.7.3 Creation of Environment for Preparing Block Development Plan
 - 7.7.4 Consolidating GPDPS and Identifying and Prioritising Developmental Needs
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 - 7.7.6 Visioning Exercise
 - 7.7.7 Resources for Planning by Intermediate Panchayats
 - 7.7.8 Focus Areas of Planning at Block Level
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 - 7.7.10 Convergence with Schemes and Programmes of Line Departments
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 - 7.7.12 Plan Preparation and Approval of Block Development Plan
 - 7.7.13 Plan Implementation
 - 7.7.14 Monitoring System, Course Correction and Modification of Block Development Plan
- 7.8 Implementation and Monitoring of Block Development Plans
- 7.9 Block Development Plans Through E-Gram Swaraj and GIS
- 7.10 Let Us Sum Up
- 7.11 Keywords
- 7.12 Suggested Readings

7.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit seeks to provide an understanding of the concept of block level planning and its role in development of an area. It also deals with the progress in block level planning, preparation of Block Development Plans, its monitoring and implementation. To start with, we will discuss the concept of block level planning and attempts in the past towards block level planning. We will then deal with specific components of block planning and the process is to be followed in the preparation of block development plans. After reading this unit, you will be able to:

- State the objectives of block level planning;
- Enumerate the components of a block development plans; and
- New methods and techniques used for preparation, implementation and monitoring block development plan.

7.1 INTRODUCTION

In prior units of this block, you learned generally about planning and its multi-tier structure. You have made yourself familiar with the planning process at the Centre (Macro-level planning) and State level (Meso-level planning). In the previous units, you also read about Multi Level Planning and District Level Planning. In this unit, you will learn about block level planning which is the level below the district level planning (Micro-level planning). Block-level planning in India has been adopted to start planning from the lowest levels. The need for this level of planning for comprehensive development of rural communities was however, recognized much earlier. Planning at this level is looked after the failure of Community Development Programme. Although the programme failed but block continued to become an important unit of micro-level planning below the district. The Fifth Five Year Plan (1978-83) opted for area planning with a preference for block-level planning which has been the fundamental improvement since the beginning of network improvement and is a unit of the Panchayati Raj framework of 73rd Amendment Act of 1992. Panchayati Raj Institution is a system of rural local self-government in India. Local Self Government is the management of local affairs by such local bodies who have been elected by the local people. Panchayati Raj Institution was constitutionalized through the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, of 1992 to build democracy at the grass roots level and was entrusted with the task of rural development in the country. The 73rd and 74th amendments in Indian Constitution have given a new direction to the planning process in India. The primary aims of these amendments is to introduce the planning process at the grass-root level. This is done by involving Panchayat for identifying the problems at the grass-root level and initiate decentralization of the entire planning process. In its present form and structure Panchayati Raj Institution has completed 26 years of existence. However, a lot remains to be done in order to further decentralize and strengthen democracy at the grass root level.

“If we would see our dream of Panchayat Raj, i.e., true democracy realized, we would regard the humblest and lowest Indian as being equally the ruler of India with the tallest in the land.”— Mahatma Gandhi

7.2 CONCEPT OF BLOCK LEVEL PLANNING

Concept

In a decentralized economy, economic planning is to be undertaken for the welfare of the local people. Economic planning will utilize all the quotidian

and all mundane potentialities of the local area to meet the local requirements. Planning should function on various levels such as the block, district, state, national and global levels, but block-level planning will be the basic level of planning. Block-level planning is essential for economic decentralization, so it should be adopted in all blocks. There should be provision in the constitution for block-level planning for socio-economic development.

Meaning and Scope

Block Level Planning is micro-minor level region planning which is associated with what is called grass-root level planning.

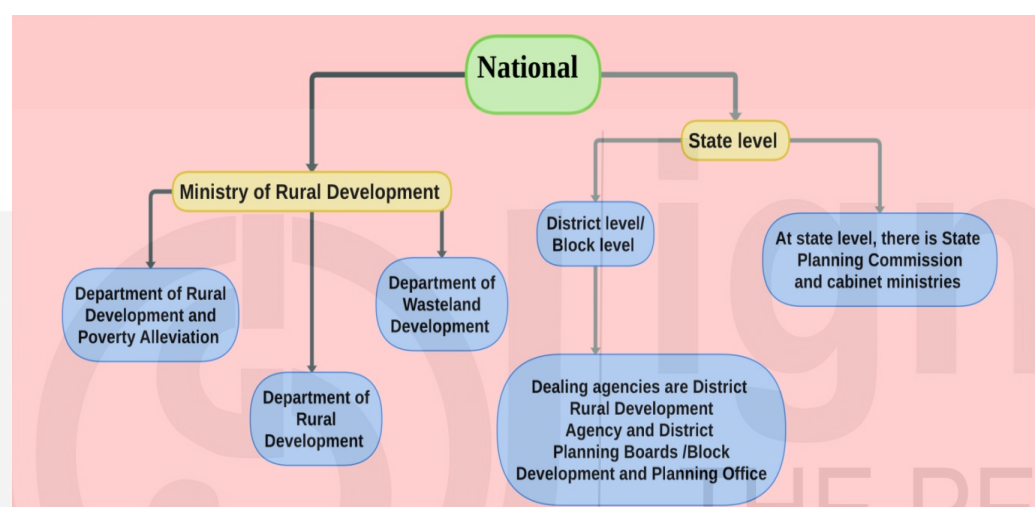


Fig. 1: Three Tier Hierarchy in Rural Areas

Block as indicated in figure 1 is suitable and manageable administrative unit in the context of regional planning. Block level planning thereby is a micro level unit of planning of rural areas. It is directly related to planning of local resources, engaging the problems and potentials of the area. The micro-minor level region can be a block for which data exists now and for which there may be a plan. The block level plan is integrated with the national plan through the district and state level plan. A block level plan is not surgically cut portion of the district plan, which has its own logic and linkage. At block level most of the officers will be more concerned with the implementation of the plans rather than formulating the plans. At block level the main exercise will be to take into account the physical and human resources and to find out the prime moving activities which will enable the block people to make the best use of the development potentials of the block to meet the basic needs of the people. So block is an important unit of micro-level planning. These development blocks were created to supervise the implementation of development plans under the Community Development Programme initiated during the First Five Year Plan. Each district was divided into a number of blocks and each block comprised about 100 villages, with a population of

about 60,000. The programme visualized mobilization of local resources, participation of the people in the decision-making and implementation of the development schemes. Hence, a new unit of planning was created at block-level under the leadership of a block development officer and a team of various specialists and village level workers (officers). The general supervision of blocks was made by the Block Samitis under the chairmanship of the Block Pramukh and elected representatives.

The amount of natural and human resources varies from block to block, hence separate economic plans will have to be made for each and every block. There should be a block-level planning board in every block for this purpose. The block-level planning body will prepare a plan for the development of the block and accordingly implement the local developmental programmes. Above the block level there will be a district-level planning board. Thus, from the block level onwards, there will be planning boards to prepare and implement the local plans and programmes. It must be noted that planning should be of ascending order, starting at the block level, and including all the levels of a socio-economic unit.

Most blocks are currently demarcated on the basis of political considerations. Block divisions should be reorganized according to such factors as the physical features of the area (including river valleys, varying climatic conditions, topography, the nature of the soil, the type of flora and fauna, etc.), the socio-economic requirements and problems of the people, and their physiological and psychological aspirations. Thus, blocks should be scientifically and systematically demarcated as the basis for efficient decentralized economic planning.

Each block should be made economically sound so that the entire socio-economic unit will be self-sufficient. Only then will a country or federation become economically strong and developed in the real sense.

When planning is prepared for the all-round growth of a single block exclusively, it is called “intra-block planning”. Each block must have its own developmental plan, adjusting with the overall plan of the socio-economic unit at various levels.

However, there are problems which traverse block boundaries and cannot be tackled or solved by one block alone, such as flood control, river valley projects, communication systems, higher educational institutions, afforestation projects, the environmental impact of development, the establishment of key industries, soil erosion, water supply, power generation, the establishment of an organized market system, etc. So, cooperation among blocks is necessary. Planning among blocks is called “inter-block planning”. Inter-block planning is an economic venture into some selected fields to organize and harmonize socio-economic development in a few adjoining blocks through mutual coordination and cooperation.

At each and every level of planning, there should be short-term and long-term

planning. In all cases, the maximum time limit for short-term planning should be six months, and the maximum time limit for long-term planning should be three years. Short-term and long-term plans should be drafted in such a way that they are complementary to each other. The immediate goals of planning at each level is to guarantee the minimum requirements of the local people, eliminate unemployment, increase purchasing capacity and make socio-economic units self-sufficient.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Write your answers in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answers with the text.

1) What do you understand by the term Block Level Planning?

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2) Briefly describe the various factors taken into consideration for Block level planning.

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7.3 BENEFITS OF BLOCK LEVEL PLANNING

There are many benefits to block-level planning. The main benefits of block level planning can be summarize as below:

- i) The area of planning is small enough for the planners to understand all the problems of the area. So, Planners can better understand the major and minor problems of the area.
- ii) Local leaders know the local problems and needs so local leaders will be able to solve the problems as per the local needs.
- iii) Planning will be more practical, effective and more readily implemented for quick, positive results.
- iv) Local socio-cultural bodies or Local organizations can play an active role in mobilizing human and material resources.
- v) Problem of unemployment can be solved easily and can be easily prevented also.

- vi) The purchasing capacity of the local people will be enhanced.
- vii) Lastly, a balanced economy can be more readily established.

The development of local industries will provide immediate economic benefits. The unemployment problem will be rapidly solved, and in a short time it will be possible to create a congenial environment for permanent full employment. In fact, the only way to solve unemployment and bring about full employment throughout the world is by developing block-level industries. The growth of local industries will provide social security to the local people and create greater opportunities for their all-round advancement, because all their basic needs will be met.

The population of every socio-economic unit should be organized on a scientific basis. The problem of a floating population should be tackled at the block level itself. Where there is a floating population, it should be either permanently settled or returned to its original region. If planning is undertaken primarily at the block level, it will have many benefits.

7.4 OBJECTIVES OF BLOCK LEVEL PLANNING

The objectives of economic policy and the goals of national planning have been fairly well defined. The objectives of block level planning obviously should be in conformity with the national goals and as such should not require reiteration. According to Dantwala committee main objective of block level planning are as follows:

- i) Optimum utilisation of the growth potentials of the area leading to increase in income and employment.
- ii) Ensuring that a larger than proportionate gains of development occur to the weaker sections of the population – small and marginal farmers, share-croppers, agricultural labourers, rural artisans, etc.
- iii) Fulfillment of the minimum needs programme like health and medical facilities, drinking water, housing, education and supply of essential commodities through a public distribution system.
- iv) Building up of social and economic infrastructure to achieve the above objectives.
- v) Reorienting the existing Institutions/ organisations in order to protect the interest of the poor.
- vi) Building up of appropriate organisations of the poor especially to protect them from exploitation.
- vii) Promotion of a process progressively more egalitarian structure of ownership of assets.
- viii) Augmenting the duration and productivity of employment of the poor by upgrading the technology, imparting of skills and setting up of non-exploitative institutions for credit, marketing and extensions.

- ix) Alleviating residual unemployment through employment on public works.

To summarize the above objectives of the Dantwala committee these can be categorized into social and economic objectives.

a) Social objectives of block level planning are as follows:

- Removal of disparities.
- Progressive elimination of exploitation and injustice.
- To encourage peoples' initiative and participation to inculcate in them the spirit of self-reliance.
- To foster community feeling and sense of mutual help, cooperation and sharing among the people.

b) Economic objectives of block level planning are as follows:

- To provide opportunities for full and gainful employment to every person in the community, starting from the poorest.
- Bringing local resources and means of production progressively within the control and direction of the local community in order to make equality a reality.
- Use of local resources both material and human supplemented by outside inputs wherever necessary.
- Production oriented to the meeting of basic and minimum needs with surplus available for capital formation and further development.
- To plan infrastructural facilities, such as roads, markets, energy sources, warehouses, agricultural inputs, distribution centers and cooperatives.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: a) Write your answer in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answer with the text.

1) Briefly describe the objectives of block level planning?

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7.5 PROGRESS IN BLOCK LEVEL PLANNING IN INDIA

Block level planning exists from a long time in India. Indian villages had Panchayats (council of five persons) from very ancient time, which were having both executive and judicial powers and used to handle various issues (land distribution, tax collection etc.) or disputes arising in the village area. Gandhiji also held the opinion of empowerment of Panchayats for the development of rural areas. Thus, recognizing their importance, our Constitution makers included a provision for Panchayats in part IV of our constitution (directive principles of state policy). Article 40 confers the responsibility upon State to take steps to organize village Panchayats and endow them with such powers and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as units of self-government. But it does not give guidelines for organizing village panchayats. Thus, its formal organization and structure was firstly recommended by Balwant Rai Committee, 1957. This Committee was formed to examine the Community Development Programme, 1952. Community Development Programme was launched on 2nd October, 1952 on pilot basis. It was a multi project programme with the following main aims — **Firstly** to provide a substantial increase in the country's agricultural production and for improvements in the system of communications, in rural health and hygiene and in village education. **Secondly** to initiate and direct a process of integrated culture change, aimed at transforming the social and economic life of the villagers. Although this Programme failed but blocks were recognized as the planning unit. The Committee, in its report in November 1957, recommended the establishment of the scheme of 'democratic decentralization', which ultimately came to be known as Panchayati Raj. It recommended for a three tier system at village, block and district level and it also recommended for direct election of village level Panchayat. Rajasthan was the first state to establish Panchayati Raj as it started from Nagaur district on October 2, 1959. After this, Ashok Mehta Committee on Panchayati Raj was appointed in December 1977 and in August 1978 submitted its report with various recommendations to revive and strengthen the declining Panchayati Raj system in the country. Its major recommendation was two tier system of Panchayat, regular social audit, representation of political parties at all levels of Panchayat elections, provisions for regular election, reservation to SCs/STs in Panchayat and a minister for Panchayati raj in state council of ministers. Further, G V K Rao Committee appointed in 1985 again recommended some measures to strengthen Panchayati Raj institutions. LM Singhvi Committee appointed in 1986 first time recommended for the constitutional status of Panchayati Raj institutions and it also suggested for constitutional provisions to ensure regular, free and fair elections of the Panchayati Raj Bodies. In response to the recommendations of LM Singhvi committee, a bill was introduced in the Lok Sabha by Rajiv Gandhi's government in July 1989 to constitutionalize Panchayati Raj Institutions, but the bill was not passed in Rajya Sabha. The

V P Singh government also brought a bill, but fall of the government resulted in lapse of the bill. After this P V Narashima Rao's government introduced a bill for this purpose in Lok Sabha in September, 1991 and the bill finally emerged as the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 and came into force on 24th April, 1993.

Administration at Block Level: Panchayat Samiti or Block Samiti

Panchayat samiti is a rural local government (panchayat) body at the intermediate tehsil (taluka/Mandal) level in India. It works for the villages of the tehsil that together are called a development block. It has been said to be the “panchayat of panchayats”.

The 73rd Amendment defines the levels of Panchayati raj institution as :

- District level
- Intermediate level (Block level)
- Base level (village Panchayat)

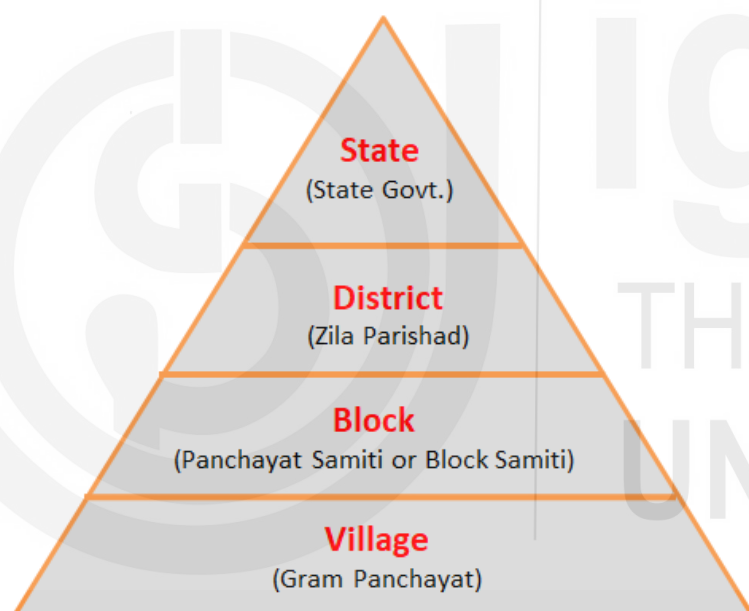


Fig. 2: Levels of Panchayati Raj Institution

Constitutional Provision for Planning at Block and District Level

Article 243G of the Constitution of India has the following provision: “243G Powers, authority and responsibilities of Panchayat — Subject to the provisions of this Constitution, the Legislature of a State may, by Law, endow Panchayats with such powers and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as institutions of self-government and such law may contain provisions for the devolution of powers and responsibilities upon Panchayats, at the appropriate level, subject to such conditions as may be specified therein, with respect to —

- a) The preparation of plans for economic development and social justice;

- b) The implementation of schemes for economic development and social justice as may be entrusted to them including those in relation to the matters listed in the “Eleventh Schedule.”

The above provision is intended to empower all the three tiers of Panchayats by enabling the State Governments to devolve powers and authority including those matters listed in the Eleventh Schedule of planning for economic Development, Social Justice and implementation of schemes in their area. This will also include the powers to impose taxes and provisions of funds to Panchayats. The Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution of India contains the following subjects:

1. Agriculture, including agricultural extension	11. Drinking water	21. Cultural activities
2. Land improvement, implementation of land reforms, land consolidation and soil conservation.	12. Fuel and fodder	22. Markets and fairs
3. Minor irrigation, water management and watershed development	13. Road, culverts, bridges, ferries, waterways and other means of communication	23. Health and sanitation including hospitals, primary health centres and dispensaries.
4. Animal Husbandry, Dairying and poultry	14. Rural electrification, including distribution of electricity	24. Family welfare
5. Fisheries	15. Non-conventional sources of energy	25. Women and child development
6. Social forestry and farm forestry	16. Poverty alleviation programme	26. Social welfare, including welfare of the handicapped and mentally retarded
7. Minor forest produce	17. Education including primary and secondary school	27. Welfare of the weaker sections and in particular of schedule caste and schedule tribes
8. Small scale industries, including food processing industries	18. Technical training and vocational education	28. Public distribution system
9. Khadi, village and cottage industries	19. Adult and non-formal education	29. Maintenance of community assets
10. Rural housing	20. Libraries	

Fig. 3: Subjects Listed in Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution

All three tiers of Panchayats have been mandated to plan for economic development and social justice. The planning process has to be comprehensive and based on participatory process, which inter alia involves the full convergence with schemes of Central Ministries / Line Departments related to 29 subjects enlisted in the Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution. Panchayats have a significant role to play in the effective and efficient implementation of schemes on subjects of national importance for transformation of rural India. Thus through Article 243G of the Constitution of India, Gram Panchayats, Intermediate Panchayats and District Panchayat are mandated to formulate the GPDP, BDP and DDP respectively for the rural area.

Article 243W of the Constitution of India has mandated that State Governments to devolve powers and authority to Municipalities including those matters listed in the Twelfth Schedule of the Constitution for planning for economic Development and Social Justice and implementation of schemes in their area. Article 243ZD of the Constitution makes it mandatory for the State Governments, to constitute District Planning Committees (DPC), which are mandated to prepare Draft District Development Plan by consolidating the plans prepared by all the Panchayats and Municipalities. Thus the Constitution of India has provided meticulous structure for decentralized planning from village to district level.

The integrated rural development programme was launched in 1977. This programme was initially implemented in 2000 blocks out of a total of 5004 blocks at that time. Its broader version was presented in 1978-79 through which 2300 blocks were benefitted. Another 300 blocks were brought under this programme in 1979-80. The main objective of this programme was to provide employment opportunities to the poor rural people and to increase their assets for which provision for financial assistance was made. This programme covered poor people living below poverty line, which included small and marginal farmers, agricultural labourer, scheduled castes and scheduled tribes and economically backward people having an annual income of less than 11,000 at the time of the Eighth Five Year Plan. With a view to give maximum benefit to the most vulnerable families, it was decided that at least 50 per cent of the families should be from the scheduled castes and scheduled tribes. Besides, reserved benefit was 40 per cent for women and 3 per cent for handicapped people. Rather than individuals, families were selected and among families too, women were given priority.

The programme visualized mobilization of local resources, participation of the people in the decision-making and implementation of the development schemes. Hence, a new unit of planning was created at block-level under the leadership of a block development officer and a team of various specialists and village level workers (officers). The Fifth Five Year Plan (1974-79) opted for area planning with a preference for block-level planning. The main objective of this planning was to absorb local labour surpluses and greater involvement of people in the formulation and implementation of development plans. Hence, by the end of 1983, system of block level planning integrated into national system was available. The relevance of block-level planning is based on the viable area and population-size. Its focus is more towards the regional and local problems, easier identification of target groups, optimum utilization of local resources, greater participation of people in plan formulation and implementation.

During the Sixth Plan period, because of the special emphasis placed on agricultural development and decentralized democracy there was a demand for further decentralization of the planning process to block-level. Providing employment to every able-bodied person was one of the chief objectives of

this planning. However, there has been a lack of understanding about the concept of block-level planning on the part of various agencies. Block-level planning as contemplated by the regional planners is supposed to be a multi-purpose plan for the overall development in the area concerned and thus they conceived it as an area-oriented, rather than a target-group oriented plan. When the Planning Commission introduced block-level planning, the main idea was to confine the development activities to the agriculture development plans, animal husbandry, fishing, forestry development plans, and so on. Besides, the Minimum Needs Programme', which was intended to ensure a minimum supply of certain essential merit goods, came to be implemented through the block plan. In practice, therefore the block-level planning has been converted into integrated rural development planning and this latter type of planning has come to be defined as a plan for uplifting the poorest families in the block above the poverty line. Ultimately, under the Sixth Plan, through I.R.D.P. block-level planning has been converted into what may be termed as the employment generation programme. During the Seventh and the Eighth Plan also, emphasis continued on rural employment and removal of poverty along the lines as during the earlier plans. The emphasis on employment generation was embodied in Tenth Plan too. Planning process needs to be decentralized further through the participation of local bodies such as Panchayats. The Panchayati Raj Institutions have been given greater autonomy and powers. However, there has not been much change in the planning approach. The concept of block-level planning has thus been misunderstood and misapplied in most cases. With increasing emphasis on community participation through Panchayati Raj institutions, role of Block Level planning in the Regional development is likely to become more potent.

The Integrated Rural Development Programme was implemented at the grassroot level through District Rural Development Agencies (DRDA) and Block Level Agencies (BLA). DRDA was established in April 1, 1999 with the objective of strengthening the programme. The funding pattern of the DRDA administration is in the ratio of 75:25 between the Centre and the States for non-NE States and 90: 10 for NE-States. In the case Union Territories, it is hundred per cent under the scheme. The governing body DRDAs include local MPs, MLAs, Chairman of Zila Parishad, Heads of District Development Departments, representatives of Scheduled Castes and Schedule Tribes, and women. Staff of blocks is responsible for implementing the programme at the grassroot level. At the state level, this programme is implemented by the State Level Coordination Committee. Ministry of Rural Areas and Employment is responsible for providing financial assistance, framing policies, guiding the implementation of policies, and evaluating the programme at the central level. Some of the important programmes are National Rural Employment Programme (NREP), Training of Rural Youth for Self-Employment (TRYSEM), Development of Women and Children in Rural Areas (DWCRA), Indira Awas Yojna (IAY), Council for Advancement of People Action and Rural Technology (CAPART), Jawahar Rojgar Yojna, the Ganga Kalyan Yojna, etc.

**National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, 2005 No. 42 of 2005
[5th September, 2005.]**

“An Act to provide for the enhancement of livelihood security of the households in rural areas of the country by providing at least one hundred days of guaranteed wage employment in every financial year to every household whose adult members volunteer to do unskilled manual work and for matters connected there with or incidental”

When NREGA (National Rural Employment Guarantee Act) was passed, at the time of its launch, it was renamed as MGNREGA (Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act) 2005, is an Indian labour law and social security measure that aims to guarantee the ‘right to work’. This act was passed in September 2005 under the UPA government of Prime Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh. It aims to enhance livelihood security in rural areas by providing at least 100 days of wage employment in a financial year to every household whose adult members volunteer to do unskilled manual work. The act was first proposed in 1991 by P.V. Narasimha Rao. It was finally accepted in the parliament and commenced implementation in 625 districts of India. Based on this pilot experience, NREGA was scoped up to cover all the districts of India from 1 April 2008. The statute is hailed by the government as “the largest and most ambitious social security and public works programme in the world”. In its World Development Report 2014, the World Bank termed it a “stellar example of rural development”. The MGNREGA was initiated with the objective of “enhancing livelihood security in rural areas by providing at least 100 days of guaranteed wage employment in a financial year, to every household whose adult members volunteer to do unskilled manual work”. Another aim of MGNREGA is to create durable assets (such as roads, canals, ponds and wells). Employment is to be provided within 5 km of an applicant’s residence, and minimum wages are to be paid. If work is not provided within 15 days of applying, applicants are entitled to an unemployment allowance. That is, if the government fails to provide employment, it has to provide certain unemployment allowances to those people. Thus, employment under MGNREGA is a legal entitlement.

MGNREGA is to be implemented mainly by gram panchayats. The involvement of contractors is banned. Apart from providing economic security and creating rural assets, NREGA can help in protecting the environment, empowering rural women, reducing rural-urban migration and fostering social equity, among others.

The law provides many safeguards to promote its effective management and implementation. The act explicitly mentions the principles and agencies for implementation, list of allowed works, financing pattern, monitoring and evaluation, and most importantly the detailed measures to ensure transparency and accountability.

Since 1960, 30 years were expended in struggling to find suitable employment schemes in India’s vast rural hinterland. The experiences of

these decades provided important lessons to the government. These included the 'Rural Manpower Programme' which exposed the tribulations of financial management, the 'Crash Scheme for Rural Employment' on planning for outcomes, a 'Pilot Intensive Rural Employment Programme' of labour-intensive works, the 'Drought Prone Area Programme' of integrated rural development, 'Marginal Farmers and Agricultural Labourers Scheme' of rural economic development, the 'Food for Work Programme' (FWP) of holistic development and better coordination with the states, the 'National Rural Employment Programme' (NREP) of community development, and the 'Rural Landless Employment Guarantee Programme' which focusses on landless households. The Planning Commission later approved the scheme and it was adopted on national scale.

On 1 April 1989, to converge employment generation, infrastructure development and food security in rural areas, the government integrated NREP and RLEGP into a new scheme JRY. The most significant change was the decentralized implementation by involving the local people through PRIs and hence a decreasing role of bureaucracy.

On 2 October 1993, the Employment Assurance Scheme (EAS) was initiated by the then Prime Minister P.V.Narasimha Rao to provide employment to agricultural hands during the lean agricultural season. P.V. Rao had started discussions on this act in the year 1991. The role of PRIs was reinforced with the local self-government at the district level called the 'Zilla Parishad' as the main implementing authority. Later, EAS was merged with SGRY in 2001.

On 1 April 1999, the JRY was revamped and renamed to JGSY with a similar objective. The role of PRIs was further reinforced with the local self-government at the village level called the 'Village Panchayats' as the sole implementing authority. In 2001, it was merged with SGRY. In January 2001, the government introduced FWP (Food for Work Programme) similar to the one that was initiated in 1977. Once NREGA was enacted, the two were merged in 2006. On 25 September 2001 to converge employment generation, infrastructure development and food security in rural areas, the government integrated EAS and JGSY into a new scheme SGRY. The role of PRIs was retained with the 'Village Panchayats' as the sole implementing authority. Yet again due to implementation issues, it was merged with Mahatma Gandhi NREGA in 2006. The total government allocation to these precursors of Mahatma Gandhi NREGA had been about three-quarters of Rs.1 trillion (US\$14 billion)

According to the Eleventh Five Year Plan (2007–12), the number of Indians living on less than \$1 a day, called Below Poverty Line (BPL), was 300 million that barely declined over the last three decades ranging from 1973 to 2004, although their proportion in the total population decreased from 36 per cent (1993–94) to 28 per cent (2004–05),^[21] and the rural working-class dependent on agriculture was unemployed for nearly 3 months per year.

The UPA Government had planned to increase the number of working days from 100 to 150 before the 2014 Lok Sabha Elections in the country but failed. The NDA government has decided to provide 150 days for rain hit areas. The registration process involves an application to the Gram Panchayat and issue of job cards. The wage employment must be provided within 15 days of the date of application. The work entitlement of '120 days per household per year' may be shared between different adult members of the same household. The law also lists permissible works: water conservation and water harvesting; drought proofing including afforestation; irrigation works; restoration of traditional water bodies; land development; flood control; rural connectivity; and works notified by the government. The Act sets a minimum limit to the wage-material ratio as 60:40. The provision of accredited engineers, worksite facilities and a weekly report on worksites is also mandated by the Act. Furthermore, the Act sets a minimum limit to the wages, to be paid with gender equality, either on a time-rate basis or on a piece-rate basis. The states are required to evolve a set of norms for the measurement of works and schedule of rates. Unemployment allowance must be paid if the work is not provided within the statutory limit of 15 days. The law stipulates Gram Panchayats to have a single bank account for NREGA works which shall be subjected to public scrutiny. To promote transparency and accountability, the act mandates 'monthly squaring of accounts. To ensure public accountability through public vigilance, the NREGA designates 'social audits' as key to its implementation. The most detailed part of the Act deals with transparency and accountability that lays out role of the state, the public vigilance and, above all, the social audits. For evaluation of outcomes, the law also requires management of data and maintenance of records, like registers related to employment, job cards, assets, muster rolls and complaints, by the implementing agencies at the village, block and state level. The legislation specifies the role of the state in ensuring transparency and accountability through upholding the right to information and disclosing information proactively, preparation of annual reports by the Central Employment Guarantee Council for the Parliament and State Employment Guarantee Councils for state legislatures, undertaking mandatory financial audits by each district along with physical audit, taking action on audit reports, developing a Citizen's Charter, establishing vigilance and monitoring committees, and developing a grievance redressal system. The Act recommends establishment of 'Technical Resource Support Groups' at district, state and central level and active use of Information Technology, like creation of a 'Monitoring and Information System (MIS)' and a NREGA website, to assure quality in implementation of NREGA through technical support. The law allows convergence of NREGA with other programmes. As NREGA intends to create 'additional' employment, the convergence should not affect employment provided by other programmes.

New Amendments Proposed in 2014: Union Rural Development Minister, Nitin Gadkari, proposed to limit MGNREGA programmes within tribal and

poor areas. He also proposed to change the labour: material ratio from 60:40 to 51:49. As per the new proposal, the programme will be implemented in 2,500 backward blocks coming under Intensive Participatory Planning Exercise. These blocks are identified per the Planning Commission Estimate of 2013 and a Backwardness Index prepared by Planning Commission using 2011 census. This backwardness index consists of following five parameters – percentage of households primarily dependent on agriculture, female literacy rates, households without access to electricity, households without access to drinking water and sanitation within the premises and households without access to banking facilities. Both proposals came in for sharp criticism. A number of economists with diverse views opposed the idea of restricting or “focusing” implementation in a few districts or blocks. In the November 2014 cabinet expansion, Birender Singh replaced Nitin Gadkari as rural development minister. Among the first statements made by the new minister was an assurance that NREGA would continue in all districts. Around the same time, however, NREGA budget saw a sharp cut and in the name of ‘focusing’ on a few blocks the programme has been limited to those blocks.

New Amendments Proposed in 2017: Finance Minister *Arun Jaitley* announced Rs. 48,000 crore to be allocated to the MGNREGA as a part of *2017 Union Budget of India*.

Benefits of National Rural Employment Guarantee Act

As one of the government’s flagship development schemes, implementation of MGNREGA offers a range of benefits especially in underdeveloped rural India. The key benefits of MGNREGA are as follows:

- Providing paid guaranteed employment in rural areas
- Increased spending power in villages to drive India’s consumption growth
- Greater social inclusion for those residing in rural India
- Improvements and creation of infrastructure in Indian villages
- Better utilization of under-utilized and unutilized labour resources
- Enhancing the power of Gram Panchayats
- Better utilisation of naturally occurring land and water resources in rural areas.

Water Conservation under MGNREGA: Water conservation initiatives were taken under Mahatma Gandhi NREGA. The Government of India allocates significant amount of financial resources for creating water conservation structures for improving water availability and providing access to potable drinking water in rural India. The case studies presented here are a small subset of our initiatives, which throw light on how we address the issue of acute water scarcity in many parts of the country. The stories also tell us how

it helped augment livelihoods of millions of rural families. Indirect impacts like improved vegetation, retaining of soil moisture, and arresting of soil erosion are also highlighted in these stories.

National Food Security Act, 2013

The National Food Security Act 2013 also known as Right to Food Act is an Act of the Parliament of India which aims to provide subsidized food grains to approximately two thirds of India's 1.2 billion people. It was signed and came into law on 12 September 2013, retroactive to 5 July 2013. The National Food Security Act, 2013 (NFSA 2013) converts into legal entitlements for existing food security programmes of the Government of India. It includes the Midday Meal Scheme, Integrated Child Development Services Scheme and the Public Distribution System. Further, the NFSA 2013 recognizes maternity entitlements. The Midday Meal Scheme and the Integrated Child Development Services Scheme are universal in nature whereas the PDS will reach about two-thirds of the population (75% in rural areas and 50% in urban areas). Under the provisions of the bill, beneficiaries of the Public Distribution System (or, PDS) are entitled to 5 kilograms per person per month of cereals at the following prices:

- Rice at Rs.3 per kg
- Wheat at Rs.2 per kg
- Coarse grains (millet) at Rs.1 per kg.

Pregnant women, lactating mothers, and certain categories of children are eligible for daily free, cereals. The bill has been highly controversial. It was introduced into India's parliament on 22 December 2011, promulgated as a presidential ordinance on 5 July 2013, and enacted into law on 12 September 2013. Odisha government implemented food security bill in 14 districts from 17 November 2015. Assam government implemented Act on 24 December 2015.

The salient features of the National Food Security Bill, 2011 are as under:

Objective: To provide for food and nutritional security in human life cycle approach, by ensuring access to adequate quantity of quality food at affordable prices to people to live a life with dignity.

Coverage under the Targeted Public Distribution System (TPDS): Up to 75% of the rural population (with at least 46% belonging to the priority households) and up to 50% of the urban population (with at least 28% belonging to the priority households) are proposed to be covered under TPDS. Corresponding to the above all India coverage, State-wise distribution will be determined by the Central Government.

Identification of Households: Identification of priority and general households is to be done by the State Governments or such other agency, in

accordance with guidelines for identification prescribed by the Central Government, provided that no household falling under exclusion criteria will be included either in the priority or general households.

Entitlements and Prices under TPDS: Priority households will be entitled to 7 kg. of food grains per person per month at prices not exceeding Rs. 3, Rs. 2 and Re.1 per kg. for rice, wheat, coarse grains, respectively and general households will be entitled to not less than 3 kg. of food grains per person at prices not exceeding 50% of the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for wheat and coarse grains and not exceeding 50% of derived MSP for rice.

Entitlements for women and children: There is a special focus in the Bill on nutritional support to women and children. Pregnant women and lactating mothers, besides being entitled to nutritious meals as per the prescribed nutritional norms, will also receive maternity benefit @ Rs. 1000/- per months for six months. Children in the age group of 6 months to 6 years will be entitled to take home ration or hot cooked meal as per the prescribed nutritional standards. Higher nutritional norms have been prescribed for children in the age group of 6 months to 6 years who are malnourished. Children in the lower and upper primary classes will be entitled to mid-day meals as per the prescribed nutritional norms.

Other entitlements: National Food Security Bill (NFSB) contains provisions for meals, free of charge or at affordable prices, as the case may be, to special groups such as destitute and homeless, as well as emergency and disaster affected persons and persons living in starvation. The Bill also provides that every State Government shall prepare and notify guidelines for prevention, identification and relief to cases of starvation. Food grains for these schemes, as well as schemes for women and children, will be provided by Central Government at prices specified for priority households in Schedule I of the Bill. Meals will be provided in accordance with schemes, including cost sharing, to be prescribed by the Central Government.

Food Security Allowance: The Central Government will provide funds to States/UTs in case of short supply of food grains from Central pool. In case of non-supply of food grains or meals to entitled persons, the concerned State/UT Governments will be required to provide such food security allowance as may be prescribed by the Central Government.

Reforms in TPDS: Central and State Governments should endeavor to progressively undertake reforms in TPDS, such as doorstep delivery of food grains, application of information and communication technology (ICT) including end to end computerization, leveraging Aadhaar 'for unique identification of beneficiaries, diversification of commodities under TPDS, etc.

Women Empowerment: The eldest woman of eighteen years of age or above will be head of the household for issue of ration card, and if not available, the eldest male member is to be the head of the household.

Grievance Redressal Mechanism: An independent three-tier mechanism-District Grievance Redressal Officer (DGRO), State Food Commission and National Food Commission — has been proposed to redress grievances relating to delivery of entitlements and related issues. Besides, Central and State Governments will also be required to put in place an internal grievance redressal mechanism.

Role of Local Authorities: The Bill provides for role of local authorities (Panchayats, municipalities, etc.) in proper implementation of the Act in their respective areas. State Governments may also assign additional responsibilities to local authorities in implementation of TPDS or other schemes of Central and State Governments.

Transparency and Accountability: Provisions have also been made for disclosure of records relating to PDS, social audits and setting up of Vigilance Committees in order to ensure transparency and accountability.

Special focus on vulnerable groups in remote, hilly and tribal areas: The Bill provides that while implementing provisions of the Act and scheme thereunder, special focus shall be given to the needs of vulnerable groups especially in remote areas, and other areas which are difficult to access, hilly and tribal areas, for ensuring their food security.

Enabling Provisions: Provisions for revitalizing agriculture, broad based procurement, encouraging decentralized procurement, augmentation of storage capacity, etc. have been made for advancing food security. The Bill also contains provisions for access to safe and adequate drinking water and sanitation, health care, nutritional, health and educational support to adolescent girls and adequate pension for senior citizens, persons with disability and single women. Introduction of schemes for cash transfer, food coupons, among others, in areas and in the manner to be prescribed by the Central Government have also been included.

Penalty: The Bill provides for penalty to be imposed on public servants or authority, by the State and National Food Commission if found guilty of failing to comply with the relief recommended by the DGRO.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: a) Write your answer in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answer with the text.

1) Write a note on Panchayati Raj Institutions?

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2) Write a note on MNREGA?

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7.6 BLOCK PLANNING FOR BENEFICIARY ORIENTED PROGRAMMES

Many beneficiary oriented programmes, such as IRDP, are implemented at the block level. This requires planning at the block level, so that the programme is implemented effectively. In fact, poverty alleviation programmes and those designed to benefit the disadvantaged need to be integrated into block plans. Some of the important projects initiated under Integrated Rural Development Programmes are briefly describe as under:

- 1) **Training of Rural Youth for Self Employment (TRYSEM):** Initiated on 15th August, 1979, this is an integral part of IRDP. Young people in the age group of 18-35 years are selected to become skilled workers and they are imparted technical training also. They are trained in such a way that they become capable of starting their own work for self-employment. Young people are selected from families having income less than 3,500 per annum and poorest of the poor are given priority. Only one member is selected from each family. Preferential treatment is given to people belonging to Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, Ex-Army men and also those people who have participated in the National Adult Education for nine months.
- 2) **Supply of Tools Kits in Rural Areas (SITRA):** This scheme aims at providing quality implements to rural artisans so that they are able to improve quality and increase the quantity of their products. As many as 7.46 lakh kits of implements costing 14.8 million were distributed among the rural artisans during 1992-93 to 1997-98.
- 3) **Development of Women and Children in Rural Areas (DWCRA):** This programme aimed at improving the income levels of women belonging to poor families. Groups of 5 to 10 women are constituted so that they can help each other in work and increase their income. The programme is based on equal contribution by the central and state governments as well as by UNICEF. Basic facilities like women's health, education, child care and nutritive food are also provided.
- 4) **Council for Advancement/Peoples Action and Rural Technology (CAPART):** Set-up on 1st September, 1986, it is an autonomous organization under the Ministry of Rural Development and acts as a

funding agency for voluntary organisations. Its primary objective is to promote voluntary action through community participation and to propagate rural technologies for the benefit of downtrodden people (SC/ST/OBC and others) living in rural areas.

- 5) **Jawahar Rojgar Yojna:** This scheme came into being due to the merger of National Rural Employment Programme (NREP) and Rural Landless Employment Guarantee Programme (RLEG) in April, 1989. The primary objective of this scheme is to provide additional employment opportunities to unemployed and under-employed men and women and to increase their assets. Besides, this scheme aims at improving the living conditions of the villagers and to provide sustainable employment. The funding by the centre and the state governments for this scheme are in the ratio of 80 : 20. For schedule caste and schedule tribes, 22.5 per cent of the allocation is reserved. The other components of this scheme are assistance to those below poverty line. This scheme was further strengthened in the Ninth Five Year Plan so that it could work more effectively.
- 6) **Indira Aawas Yojna (IAY):** This scheme was initiated as a sub-scheme of Jawahar Rojgar Yojana in May, 1985. It aims at providing financial assistance to extremely poor people belonging to SC/STs, for constructing their houses and for repairing the dilapidated kutchha houses. Since 1995-96, this benefit has been extended to war widows and retired workers of military and para-military forces, subject to their qualifying the laid conditions. About 3 per cent of the allocated funds have been reserved for disabled people living below poverty line. People living below poverty line and belonging to minority communities have also been included among the beneficiaries from this scheme. IAY is being implemented across the country (except Delhi and Chandigarh) and funding for this scheme is shared between the centre and the states in the ratio of 75:25. In case of union territories, the entire fund is provided by the centre. In case of north-eastern states the funding ratio between the centre and states is 90 : 10. With effect from April 1st, 2010, the ceiling on construction assistance under IAY scheme is Rs. 45,000 per unit in the plain areas and Rs. 48,500 in the hilly/difficult areas. For upgrading kutchha house, the financial assistance to Rs. 15,000 per unit. During 2010-11, as against the target of constructing Rs. 29.69 lakh houses, only Rs. 14.57 lakh houses were constructed. Since its inception, about 2 Rs. 86.88 lakh houses have been constructed with an expenditure of Rs. 85141.13 crore.
- 7) **Swarnajayanti Gram Swarojgar Yojna/ National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM):** This scheme was launched on 1st April, 1999 and is designed as a holistic self-employment scheme aimed at providing sustainable income to rural BPL (below poverty line) families through income generating assets/economic activities so as to bring them above

the poverty line. Thrust is on empowerment of the vulnerable sections of the society, is 50% for SC/STs, 40% for women, 15% for minorities and 3% for disabled persons. Assistance under Swarnajayanti Gram Swarojgar Yojna to individuals or Self-Help Groups (SHGs) is given in the form of Revolving Funds Assistance and Capital Subsidy by the government linked credit by the banks. Since its inception upto March, 2012, Rs. 43.34 lakh SHGS have been formed and Rs. 14.46 lakh SHGs have taken up economic activities.

- 8) **Employment/Assurance Scheme:** Poor labourers do not get any employment during the lean season in agricultural operations. The Government of India launched scheme for employment assurance on 2nd October, 1993 in some selected blocks. National Rural Employment Guarantee Act was passed which was implemented for 200 most backward districts of the country in its first phase. In the second phase, it was implemented for 130 districts in 2007-08 and for 274 districts in the third phase after 1st April, 2008.

This is the first law which guarantees employment opportunities to the poor people on such a large scale. Its other aims are to provide safety against droughts, deforestation, soil erosion etc. for sustainable growth. These are some of the factors responsible for poverty.

- 9) **Million Wells Scheme:** This programme was started in 1988-89 as a sub-programme of National Rural Employment Programme (NREP) and Rural Landless continued to work as a sub-programme of Jawahar Rojgar Yojna from 1st April 1989 to 31st December 1995 and became a full-fledged independent programme on 1st January, 1996. The main purpose of this scheme is to provide irrigation facilities to small and marginal farmers living below poverty line and to bonded labourers who have been freed from the clutches of their masters. This scheme was basically meant for people belonging to SCs and BCs but poor people belonging to other castes were also included in 1993-94. There is provision for 3% reservation for physically handicapped persons. Panchayati Raj organisations are doing a wonderful job preparing the list of beneficiaries from this scheme.
- 10) **Ganga Kalyan Yojna (GKY):** This programme was initiated by the Central Government on 1st February 1997 to provide irrigation facilities to small and marginal farmers or groups of such farmers living below poverty line by utilizing ground water through wells and tube-wells. The finances for this programme are provided by government subsidy or financial organisations. The funding ratio between the Centre and the States is 80: 20. Priority is given to SCs and BCs.
- 11) **National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP):** Started on 15th August, 1995, this programme has the following three components:
 - i) Old age pension of 75 per month to people of age 65 years and above.

- ii) One-time financial assistance to those families which have lost their only earning member; Rs. 5,000 in case of natural death and Rs. 10,000 in case of accidental death.
- iii) Financial assistance to pregnant women living below poverty line for the birth of first two children under National Maternity Benefit Scheme (NMBS), provided the women is above 19 years of age.

12) **Total Sanitation Campaign (TSC):** Rural sanitation came into focus of the Government of India during the World Water Decade of 1980s. The Central Rural Sanitation Programme (CRSP) was started in 1986 for providing sanitation facilities in rural areas. Following are the main objectives of this campaign:

- i) Bring about an improvement in the general quality of life in the rural areas.
- ii) Accelerate sanitation coverage in rural areas.
- iii) Generate felt demand for sanitation facilities through awareness creation and health education.
- iv) Cover schools/anganwadis in rural areas with sanitation facilities and promote hygiene education and sanitary habits among students.
- v) Encourage cost effective and appropriate technologies in sanitation.
- vi) Eliminate open defecation to minimize risk of contamination of drinking water sources and food.
- vii) Convert dry latrines to pour flush latrines, and eliminate manual scavenging practice, wherever it is in existence in rural areas.

13) **Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act 2005 (MGNREGA):** Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), also known as Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MNREGS) is Indian legislation enacted on August 25, 2005. The MGNREGA provides a legal guarantee for one hundred days of employment in every financial year to adult members of any rural household willing to do public work-related unskilled manual work at the statutory minimum wage. The Ministry of Rural Development (MRD), Government of India is monitoring the entire implementation of this scheme in association with state government. Following are the salient features of MGNREGA.

- a) MGNREGA guarantees hundred days of wage employment in a financial year, to a rural household whose adult members volunteer to do unskilled manual work.
- b) Individual beneficiary-oriented works can be taken up on the cards of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, small or marginal

farmers or beneficiaries of land reforms or beneficiaries under the Indira Awaas Yojana of the Government of India.

- c) Within 15 days of submitting the application or from the day work is demanded, wage employment will be provided to the applicant.
- d) Right to get unemployment allowance in case employment is not provided within fifteen days of submitting the application or from the date when work is sought.
- e) Receipt of wages within fifteen days of work done.
- f) Variety of permissible works which can be taken up by the Gram Panchayaths.
- g) MGNREGA focuses on the economic and social empowerment of women.
- h) MGNREGA provides “Green” and “Decent” work.
- i) Social Audit of MGNREGA work is mandatory, which leads to accountability and transparency.
- j) MGNREGA works address the climate change vulnerability and protect the farmers from such risks and conserve natural resources.
- k) The Gram Sabha is the principal forum for wage seekers to raise their voices and make demands. It is the Gram Sabha and the Gram Panchayat which approves the shelf of works under MGNREGA and fix their priority.

- 14) **Janmanrega:** Janmanrega is an instrument for information flow to and from ground-level, which will connect citizens with the system. An initiative towards good governance, Janmanrega is an interface to improve quality of public services. The Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) launched ‘Janmanrega’ – a Citizen-centric Mobile Application (CCMA). This was launched by Hon’ble Minister of Rural Development on 19th of June 2017. Janmanrega has been developed with collaboration between the MoRD, National Informatics Centre (NIC) and National Remote Sensing Centre (NRSC, Hyderabad). Beta Version of this Android Application is now available at Ministry’s MGNREGA Website that will allow locating already geotagged more than 1.78 crore Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme’s (MGNREGS) Assets within Indian Space Research Organisation’s (ISRO) Bhuvan Map Interface along with their attributes and two photographs using an Android mobile phone. Citizens will also be able to provide feedback about assets that have been created under the programme.

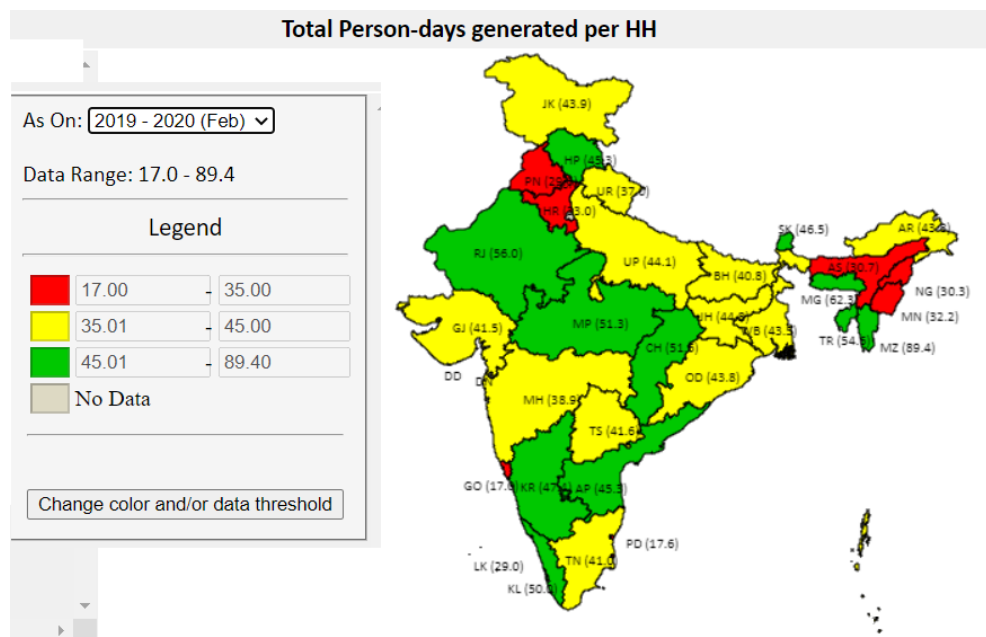


Fig. 4: Janmanrega' – a Citizen-centric Mobile Application (CCMA)

- 15) **Mission Antyodaya:** Mission Antyodaya is an accountability and convergence framework for transforming lives and livelihoods on measurable outcomes. Adopted in Union Budget 2017-18, Mission Antyodaya is a convergence and accountability framework aiming to bring optimum use and management of resources allocated by 27 Ministries/Department of the Government of India under various programmes for the development of rural areas. It is envisaged as state-led initiative with Gram Panchayats as focal points of convergence efforts. Annual survey in Gram Panchayats across the country is an important aspect of Mission Antyodaya framework. It is carried out coterminous with the People's Plan Campaign (PPC) of Ministry of Panchayat Raj and its' purpose is to lend support to the process of participatory planning for Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP).

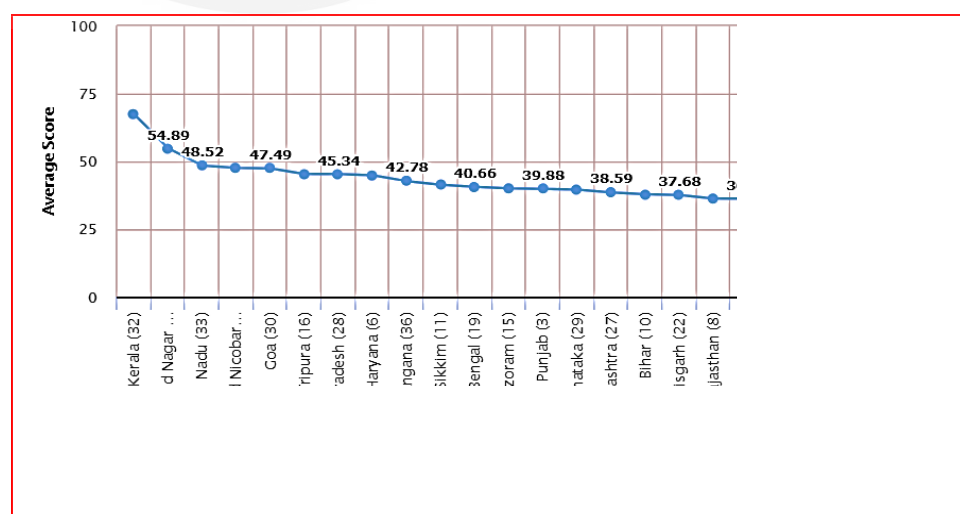


Fig. 5: Mission Antyodaya : State-wise Average Score

Objectives

- Ensuring effective use of resources through convergence of various Government Schemes with Gram Panchayats as the basic unit of planning.
- Work with a focused micro plan for sustainable livelihood for every deprived households.
- Conduct an annual survey on measurable outcomes at Gram Panchayat level to monitor the progress in the development process across rural areas.
- Supporting the process of participatory planning for Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP), which will improve service delivery, enhance citizenship, create pace for an alliance of people's institutions and groups and improve governance at the local level.
- Encourages partnerships with network of professionals, institutions and enterprises to further accelerate the transformation of rural livelihoods.

Convergence of Resources and Information

- There is a need to bring in synergies between different government programmes and schemes in terms of planning, processes and implementation to achieve the goals under SDG.
- The Planning should consider the household and the villages as the basic unit of planning that facilitates household level micro-plan and Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP).
- Harmonizing selection criteria, implementation processes and guidelines, and availability of funds at the same time is thus critical for implementation. This would need pooling of financial and human resources in different schemes of government and their rationalization in implementing the plans at HH level and GPDP.
- “Mission Antyodaya” encourages addressing all identified deprivations in a time-bound manner through intensifying coverage of government schemes to address individual, household and community-level deprivations in saturation mode.
- Provisions of public services and improving access are necessary but not sufficient to address multiple deprivations. In this endeavor, over 25 Departments/Ministries of the Government are expected to provide resources to the Antyodaya GPs/Clusters on a priority basis through their programmes with a thrust on pooling of resources and delivery in saturation mode.
- Mission Antyodaya is an accountability and convergence framework for transforming lives and livelihoods on measurable outcomes.

Stamping Out Poverty “Karenge Aur Kar Ke Rahenge”

While addressing the Lok Sabha on the 75th anniversary of the Quit India movement, the Prime Minister said from 2017 to 2022, when India turns 75, there is a need to create the same spirit that existed between 1942 and 1947. “In 1942, the clarion call was ‘Karenge Ya Mareng’ (Do or Die) – and now it is ‘Karenge Aur Kar Ke Rahenge.’ These five years are about ‘Sankalp Se Siddhi’ (commitment to fulfillment),” he said.

Terming poverty, lack of education and malnutrition as the greatest challenges, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had called for special initiatives to end all such ills in the next five years with the pledge of ‘Karenge Aur Kar Ke Rahenge’ (We will do and surely do).

- Convergence reduces poverty, raises incomes– IRMA
- Women SHGs – improved education, health, nutrition.
- ‘Islands of Excellence’ by saturation-more Hivre Bazaars
- Leveraging Bank loans promotes an enterprise model.
- Targeted coverage – Ujwala, SBM, PMAY, Skills, Power, Roads, internet.
- Driving Economic Enterprise with Physical and Social Infrastructure.
- 5000 thriving Rural Clusters – will trigger similar action for Poverty free 2022.

Coordination Arrangements

- Hon’ble PM with Chief Ministers of States reviewing in NITI Aayog Governing Council – MRD as Special Invitee.
- Steering Group under Cabinet Secretary.
- State Level Coordination under Chief Ministers.
- Steering Committee under Chief Secretary. × DISHA Committee at District level.
- Block level Panchayat Samiti.
- Gram Panchayat level Standing Committees.
- Ranking of GPs/monitoring well-being of HHs.
- 20% GPs in 2017-20, 30% in 2018-21, remaining 2019-22

Check Your Progress 3

Note: a) Write your answer in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answer with the text.

1) What do you mean by I.R.D.P.? Write in detail.

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2) Write a note on NRLM?

3) What is Mission Antyodaya?

7.7 PREPARATION OF BLOCK DEVELOPMENT PLAN

Article 243G of the Constitution of India mandates the Intermediate Panchayat to prepare the Block Development Plan (BDP) for economic development and social justice by converging and integrating all such programmes / schemes of the Panchayat, State and Centre to be implemented in their geographical area. The Constitutional provision regarding planning has been elaborated in Section 1.2 of this framework. Further, as local government, the Intermediate Panchayat are also responsible for ensuring delivery of basic services to local citizens and addressing vulnerabilities of the poor and marginalized sections of the population in their area. This can only be achieved through implementation of a comprehensive plan through efficient and responsible utilization of available resources and expanding the resources to cater to their needs. Further, it has to be ensured that there should not be duplication of their works with those undertaken / to be undertaken by the Gram Panchayat and District Panchayat and line departments in their respective area.

Over the last two and half decades, several initiatives have been taken by the State and Central Governments to encourage participatory planning process at the level of the Intermediate Panchayat. However, various challenges such as inadequate resources, low people's participation, low capacity etc. have hindered the pace of formulation of comprehensive and visionary Block

Development Plan (BDP). However, the planning of the BDP would get boost with proactive drive by the Government of India and the State Governments through the grants recommended by Fifteenth Finance Commission. Therefore, time has come to prepare the BDP in a comprehensive manner with incorporation of equity and inclusiveness.

The preparation of the Block Development Plan is a time-bound process. It is part of chain of plans to be prepared in cascading mode. It should be prepared after completion of Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GPDPs) by Gram Panchayats in their respective area in accordance with timeline outlined in Table 2. However the Intermediate Panchayat should not wait till the completion of all GPDPs in their area. They should provide the building blocks for the District Development Plan. The Block Development Plan should ideally cater to people's needs, provide basic services and meet their aspirations with optimal utilization of the available resources. It should be prepared through a participatory, inclusive and transparent process. The plan should be long-term (perspective plan) in nature (ideally for five years) and operational plan, which is implementable in a year, based on priorities arrived at Block Sabha. The Intermediate Panchayat with their moderate status in terms of manpower, infrastructure and institutional capacity can plan for and implement medium types of activities which are possible on their part to implement and monitor. Besides, it may be necessary on the part of each Intermediate Panchayat to plan for and implement those plan activities which territorially cover two or more GPs because, in such cases, the Intermediate Panchayat would be in a better position to take charge of such activities (MoPR, 2020). Only in an exceptional situation they may undertake a work of one particular Panchayat.

7.7.1 Process for Block Development Plan

The Block Development Plan may be prepared through a participatory inclusive and transparent process with modified **bottom up** approach. The development needs for the plan may be arrived at by consolidating gaps ascertained in GPDPs through Mission Antyodaya data as detailed in Section 4.1. Those gaps, which were addressed or planned to be addressed by Gram Panchayats may be excluded from the plan. Thus the Block Development Plan process envisages need based planning, supplementing GPDPs. Further, it would also strive to contribute to national commitments e.g. SDGs and priorities. The plan activities of the line departments operating at the Intermediate Panchayat level should be integrated into the Block Development Plan, although the same may be implemented by the line departments themselves. There would be sincere efforts to use expertise available in Government sector, academics and private sector.

The process, structure and format of the Block Development Plan may be largely the same as followed for the GPDP. After GPDPs are prepared and approved at GP level, the same are to be forwarded by the GPs to the Intermediate Panchayat. Those projects and activities, which are to be

implemented in more than one GP area and which should be implemented at the Intermediate Panchayat level because of its higher institutional capacity and technical competence, are to be considered by the Intermediate Panchayat for the Block Development Plan. The Plan will be approved by Block Sabha consisting of all Intermediate Panchayat members, District Panchayat members in the Block Panchayat area, GP Presidents/Sarpanches of all the Gram Panchayats from the concerned block shall be convened and this meeting has to be considered as Block Sabha. Apart from elected representatives, block level line department officials, leader of SHG federations, experts, professionals, doctors, economist etc. should also be nominated as members of Block Sabha (MoPR, 2020). There may be total 50-80 persons including aforesaid ones may be nominated as members of Block Sabha by President of the Intermediate Panchayat. The meeting of Block Sabha will be presided over by President of the Intermediate Panchayat and Block Panchayat Officer / Block Development Officer may be nominated as Convenor of Block Sabha. However, financial matter would be sanctioned by the competent authority authorized by State Government for the Intermediate Panchayat. The following may be the process for preparation of the Block Development Plan:

- i) Formation of Intermediate Planning Planning Committee (IPPC) for every Intermediate Panchayat for shared understanding and facilitation of the entire planning process orienting and activating them to take up and carry forward the entire process of the Block Development Plan.
- ii) Environment creation and community mobilization

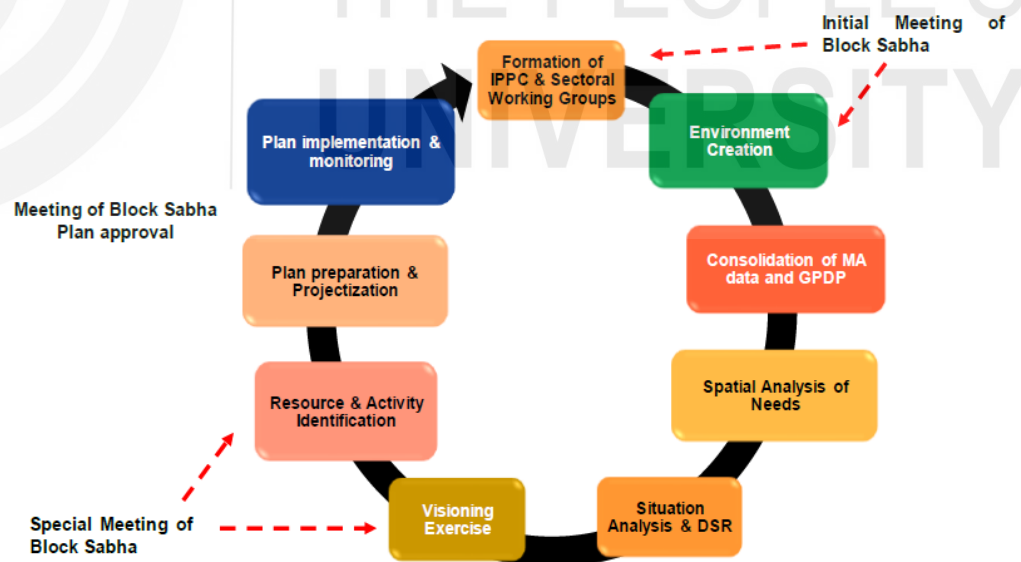


Fig. 6: Plan Cycle of Block Development Plan

- iii) Collection of primary and secondary data and consolidation of data
- iv) Situation analysis, need assessment and gap identification and preparation of Draft Development Status Report
- v. Visioning exercise for goal setting.

- vi) Resources and identification/estimation of corresponding activities Special Block Sabha.
- vii) Preparation of draft Block Development Plan based on prioritization of needs and projectization of planned activities.
- viii) Approval of the Block Development Plan Implementation, monitoring and impact analysis.

7.7.2 Formation of Intermediate Panchayat Planning Committee (IPPC) and Sectoral Working Group (SWG)

The Intermediate Panchayat should prepare the Block Development Plan with enabling wider participation, optimal utilisation of resources and getting maximum developmental benefits. Large number of well-meaning / philanthropic / voluntary human resources should be roped in who can help the Intermediate Panchayat in coming up with holistic and visionary plan. For this, a group may be formed namely Intermediate Panchayat Planning Committee (IPPC) to prepare the Block Development Plan and the Committee shall undertake the exercise of the BDP under the chairpersonship of President of the Intermediate Panchayat. In places where an eminent expert is available for supporting the planning process he or she may be nominated as the Co-Chairperson of the IPPC. The size and composition of the IPPC may vary. The representatives of sectoral/line departments at block level should invariably be the members of this team. In addition to them, the citizens of the block who are working/living elsewhere either in the country or outside should also be invited to become members of the IPPC. This is aimed at harnessing their knowledge/skills and expertise for sustainable development of the block area. The known “Beacon leaders” of other Intermediate Panchayats of the district/nearby districts/States/other States may also be invited as special invitees of the IPPC. The instructions issued by the State Government/district administration to all line departments should be leveraged to ensure whole-hearted participation of these members. The representative of NRLM or any eminent person may be nominated as Facilitator of the Committee. The Facilitator would consolidate the GPDP and Mission Antyodaya data and coordinate with the Facilitators of Gram Panchayat Planning Facilitation Team and convenor of Sectoral Working Group. A core group (facilitation team) of five persons including the President, Executive Officer and Facilitator of the Intermediate Panchayat may be constituted and intensively trained for the preparation of the Block Development Plan.

Table 1: Indicative Composition of Intermediate Panchayat Planning Committee

S.No.	Members of the Committee	Designation
1.	President of the Intermediate Panchayat	Chairperson
2.	Vice President of the Intermediate Panchayat	Vice Chairperson

3.	Five Presidents of Gram Panchayats in the Block	Members
4.	Elected Representatives of the District Panchayat representing the Block	Members
5.	Chairpersons of Standing Committees of Intermediate Panchayat	Members
6.	Block Development Officer	Members
7.	Forest Range Officer	Members
8.	Representative Of NRLM	Members
9.	Agriculture Extension Officer	Members
10.	President of Agricultural Produce Marketing Committee	Invitee
11.	Block Lead Bank Manager	Invitee
12.	One Sanitation Expert	Invitee
13.	One Professor of Economics	Invitee
14.	The Secretary or Executive Officer of the Intermediate Panchayat	Member Secretary

Note: The Committee may co-opt members in case of needs. Five Presidents of Gram Panchayats in the Block and other invitee/ member may be nominated by the President of Intermediate Panchayat.

Responsibilities of the Planning Committee: The responsibilities of the Planning Committee inter-alia shall be the following:

- To help the Intermediate Panchayat and the Sectoral Working Groups for preparing Block Development Plan and Sectoral plan respectively.
- To encourage healthy deliberations regarding development of the area.
- To support the working groups for the preparation of projects.
- To explore the additional resource mobilization possibilities.
- To ensure coordination while arranging the activities according to the timeline.
- To coordinate working group activities.
- To assist in the meetings with the stakeholders and the discussions with the banks and cooperative institutions.
- To find experts, volunteers, academic – technical institutions for assisting in preparation of the Block Development Plan.

7.7.3 Creation of Environment for Preparing Block Development Plan

There is need to create proper environment at the block level focusing on the mobilization of community and discussions with all groups of the stakeholders. This is a significant exercise to ensure that the Elected

Representatives, officials and community at large are oriented towards the planning exercise. Before the formal plan preparation is started, there is a need for environment generation and social mobilization. The environment generation activities are of immense importance to bring about attitudinal changes, outlook and orientation among the community and governance systems. Therefore, the first activity in the Block Development Plan process is to organize a Block Sabha to kick-start the planning process by creating awareness among the villagers. The Block Sabha will be made aware about the need for the Block Development Plan, the activities that will be taken up in the planning process, formation of IPPC and SWG and introduction of their members. The IPPC should take initiative in proper environment creation and ensuring wider participation of women in Block Sabha. This can be taken up with the assistance of women elected representative and SHG collectives. To involve all groups of the people in the process of decision making in Block Sabha, separate Sabha for women, children and elderly persons may be organized prior to main Block Sabha meetings to ensure better mainstreaming of their issues in the Block Development Plan. Information Education & Communication (IEC) activities should also be initiated by the Intermediate Panchayat for better dissemination of vision and goal setting under the Block Development Plan.

7.7.4 Consolidating GPDPS and Identifying and Prioritising Developmental Needs

During the last five year the preparation of Gram Panchayat Development Plans has improved substantially in adopting the comprehensive processes. An important area at the Intermediate Panchayat level is to ensure that the GPDPS are consolidated at the block level both for identifying developmental needs and planning activities to address these needs. Mission Antyodaya data are very useful for this purpose as it finds out criticality the gaps with respect to twenty nine subjects listed in the Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution.

The data related to developmental needs may be uploaded on a GIS platform (Geographical Information System Platform), which would facilitate spatial and temporal analysis using functionality of Overlay analysis. It would help in exactly identifying where and in which area the problem exists and which activity may help to address the problems. It would also help in locating number of villages and people to be impacted.

7.7.5 Situation Analysis and Development Status Report

Situation analysis is a process through which the issues and the needs of community and the developmental gaps, where intervention is needed are identified. This analysis takes into account the assessment of the current development status at the Block level. It is primarily required to assess the existing scenario on various development issues and provides basic information on the gaps in infrastructure, amenities and services that exist as well as the optimal set of activities for future development. This analysis can

serve as the basis for setting priorities to be incorporated in the Block Development Plan. Situation analysis could be effective if authentic data is available on the development achieved in different sectors during the last five years. This would act as benchmark for future goals and targets to be finalized for the Block Development Plan. The data available also needs to be cross-checked with the feedback from the community.

The draft Sectoral Working Groups reports and Development Status Report would be finalized after deliberation in Special Block Sabha. The DSR would help the Block Sabha to identify the following:

- Status of development of the Intermediate Panchayat in various thematic sectors in terms of achievements, limitations and gaps in development efforts.
- Convergence strategies for optimizing development goals for the Intermediate Panchayat.
- Prioritization of development agenda to be taken up over next five years on annual basis.
- Issues that are to be addressed by various authorities and institutions including the Intermediate Panchayat.

7.7.6 Visioning Exercise

The Visioning Exercise at the Intermediate Panchayat level needs to take into account the vision of the Intermediate Panchayats. It should aim at consolidation of the vision in the areas of economic development and social justice at the block level. Ideally the Intermediate Panchayats should prepare the vision for the next five years based on the development achieved during the past five years and also the needs and demands from the community for future development. The Visioning Exercise provides the platform to identify the local needs and demands of the community and stakeholders apart from redressal of the grievances in the quality of services provided to the community. It also provides an opportunity to identify and address issues related to the mandatory duties and responsibilities assigned to the Intermediate Panchayat under the State Panchayat Act. A draft Vision Document prepared by the IPPC may be placed before this meeting so as to receive comments and suggestions leading to finalization of the Vision.

7.7.7 Resources for Planning by Intermediate Panchayats

The Intermediate Panchayats are an important link between the Gram Panchayats and District Panchayats and are adequately equipped in terms of human resources to take up an effective planning exercise. However, there is a need to identify various resources available at the Intermediate Panchayat level for this exercise. Broadly, these resources may be classified in following four categories:

- i) Social Resources – Institutional strength, peace, social harmony/unity within the community.
- ii) Natural Resources – Land, forests, water, air and all naturally available resources.
- iii) Human Resources – People living in the Block, people associated with the area in any other capacity, women SHGs, NGOs and CBOs.
- iv) Financial Resources – Funds available from Central and State Governments, OSR, Contribution by the Community etc.

The Resource Envelope for the Intermediate Panchayats across many States is well defined with budgetary support from the State Governments and grants from Fifteenth Finance Commission. The mobilization of Own Source Revenue is nominal and is mainly through rent from buildings and other properties owned by the Intermediate Panchayats. The resource envelope of IP may consist of the following:

- 15th Finance Commission Grant
- State Finance Commission Grant
- Own Source Revenue (OSR)
- CSS and State Schemes entrusted to the Intermediate Panchayats
- Funds available to the line departments under the Central and State Government Schemes
- Voluntary contributions (cash, kind and labour)
- CSR funds if assured and available to the Intermediate Panchayats
- Funds available under the Block Credit Plan.

There are activities that are carried out within the block by GPs located in their area. Further, the activities are also taken up within the block limits by the District Panchayat. Ideally the Resource Envelope at the Intermediate Panchayat should encompass all these resources. States should identify how these resources are accounted and audited at the block level. Many States across the country have the budget link document up to the Intermediate Panchayat level and there is scope for expansion of the link document to encompass all the grants and schemes assigned to the line departments.

7.7.8 Focus Areas of Planning at Block Level

The Intermediate Panchayat are responsible for undertaking development activities in its area for economic and social development including infrastructure development through inclusive and participative planning. Further, the Intermediate Panchayat needs to coordinate and collabourate with the line departments undertaking activities assigned under the 29 subjects listed in the Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution. The Intermediate Panchayats have to ensure that the fruits of development reach the SCs, STs, women, children and other vulnerable and marginalized groups in the block. However, there is a need to identify functions in the focused areas that can be performed at the block level.

- a) **Economic Development and Income Generation:** The Panchayats have the Constitutional mandate of planning for economic development and social justice, which can be realized through an enabling policy environment with adequate resource envelope at the disposal of the Intermediate and District Panchayats. Some of the activities for economic development and income generation are follows:
- i) **Agri-allied and Agri-processing Units:** Agriculture and allied sector provide raw material to Agri-processing unit with comparative advantage over those in urban area.
 - ii) **Strengthening of Supply Chain Management:** The Intermediate Panchayats may also work for expansion of livelihood opportunities in the secondary and tertiary sectors by strengthening of supply chain management. Rising crop prices, sale of land to developers, crop rotation, export orientation and home-coming of the rural youth/migrant, government flagship schemes like MGNREGA and better wages for farm labour are creating disposable surpluses in rural areas. IP may support innovative means and promote technology in various agricultural practices, usage of renewable energy, employing communications technology, mobile refrigeration facilities, developing cold storage technologies, low-cost processing, and packaging etc. for rural transformation.
 - iii) **Development of cold chain for perishable products:** It was estimated by the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) that 40% of India's fresh fruits and vegetables worth an annual \$8.3 billion perish before reaching consumers. Cold storages could help reduce the burden on farmers and industries in transacting with other stakeholders. There are many low-cost models for cold chain. The Intermediate Panchayat may support developing a sustainable cold chain system for local products in convergence with related stakeholders.
 - iv) **Initiatives for Rural Market Hub:** In order to succeed in marketing fresh produce or processed product markets, producers and rural agro-processors must be aware of market needs in terms of product characteristics to enter the niche market. The Intermediate Panchayat may take initiative to develop Rural Market Hub to cater to the needs of population residing in the rural areas. Using Government e-Market place (GeM) may also be encouraged in this regard.
 - v) **Developing Robust Panchayat — Private Partnership:** Local economic development is not just about development of basic needs of individuals but about people working together to achieve sustainable economic growth and improved lives. The Intermediate

Panchayat must be encouraged to enter into partnership with respect to delivery of services on a commercial basis. Harnessing non-conventional energy, better management of available water and use of bio-technology for promotion of production, adoption of new technology for augmentation of livelihood opportunities etc. may be the areas of priority.

- vi) **Waste to Wealth:** India has a substantial potential for energy generation from urban, industrial and agricultural waste/residue. Bio-CNG, biogas and energy from different wastes, such as cattle dung in rural areas or vegetable/food could be used for cooking, electricity generation and transportation. The Intermediate Panchayats can take lead in creating adequate and affordable infrastructure for the relevant stakeholders to facilitate the process. Convergence and collaboration with relevant organisations and departments can be identified to utilize the resources in this regard.
- vii) **Promotion of Livelihood Opportunities in Secondary and Tertiary Sectors:** The reliance on cultivation as main source of livelihood in rural areas is declining due to demographic pressure, preponderance of small farms, declining share of house-hold income from agriculture etc. With overall economic growth, better rural infrastructure and reducing rural and urban travel time. The non-farm sector in rural India is growing fast. Thus, secondary and tertiary sector has emerged an important potential source of employment in rural India. In addition to the growth of primary sector, there is a need to tap the potential of secondary and tertiary sectors for comprehensive rural development. The Intermediate Panchayat may identify important industry, which may have comparative advantage in the area. They should mediate with the financial institutions e.g., Banks/financial institutions for providing better access to credit for deployment of the skilled workers/SHGs in production of goods and services. They must promote those activities within their areas with their resources as well as mediating with other available institutions for better implementation of the plans and programmes in those sectors. However, in each case, the project report must be examined by experts so that there is a firm economic basis for it.
- viii) **Rural Industry Cluster:** According to an estimate, Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises segment accounts for 31% of India's GDP. There are an estimated 55.80 million MSMEs employing close to 124 million people. Out of these, 14% are women led enterprises and 59.5% are in the rural areas. The Intermediate Panchayat needs to support the establishment of new MSMEs and the existing ones in cluster development mode at natural potential site and develop the cluster with the help of

private sector and community based organizations with particular support to women collectives.

- b) **Natural Resource Management:** Degradation of natural resources has a direct negative impact on livelihoods of poor people. The Intermediate Panchayat must strengthen the capacity of related community institutions to conserve, manage, and use water and forest resources in an inclusive, participative pro-poor, and sustainable manner. Their capacity needs to be augmented further in assessing availability of natural resources and in improving its utilization for generating maximum economic gains keeping in mind the need for generating optimal employment and ensuring availability of food on a sustainable basis. In the light of the responsibilities and powers given to Panchayats to manage natural resources, they emerge as the most appropriate institutional platform to manage and conserve the natural resources in their respective areas. The community-based institutional framework is also required to include different user groups that can work with the Panchayats. The Intermediate Panchayat may collabourate with related line department to build their capacity. NGOs and CBOs may provide a ground for experimentation and innovation and may help strengthening Panchayats and user groups. Partnerships with research institutions and related stakeholders may give scope for a sustainable planning for better environment friendly rural areas.
- c) **Disaster Risk Management:** Proper management of disaster depends on due preparedness and many of those activities are to be taken up at the community level. Each Gram Panchayat will be required to develop a Disaster Management Plan in consultation with the community for mitigating the impact of any disaster and to take as much pre-emptive action as possible. A major challenge is developing capacities of the local bodies and the community for that purpose. The Intermediate Panchayats should build such capacities of Panchayats with emphasis on areas which are more prone to certain types of disaster like cyclone, flood etc. While preparing plans, the Intermediate Panchayat must allocate resources for building infrastructures such as construction of flood shelter house. In flood prone areas an appropriate toilet along with innovative design should be given priority. The Intermediate Panchayats have a very important role to play in both preparedness and mitigation of calamities, in mobilizing and organizing the people as well as facilitate their capacity building of all related stakeholders. Further, Intermediate Panchayat need to integrate Disaster Risk Reduction activities with climate change adaptation (CCA) interventions for long terms sustainable development and vulnerability reduction strategies. Adopting best practices for future risk mitigation strategies and reducing environmental stresses need to be integrated into the Block Development Plan.

d) **Ensuring Social Justice:** Article 243 G of the Constitution of India mandated Panchayats to ensure social justice in rural areas. It inter alia implies removal of inequalities and providing equal opportunities to all sections of the society to participate in the process of development. Social justice also encompasses affirmative actions, targeted funding to the vulnerable, pro-poor service delivery etc. The Intermediate Panchayat are responsible for implementation of many social assistance programmes and schemes. Some of the major issues that can be incorporated in the Block Development Plan are as follows:

- Scholarships, allowance and opportunities to people with disabilities
- Addressing needs of SCs/STs and other marginalized groups
- Effective implementation of government schemes and programmes
- Monitoring of PDS and ensuring food security
- Infrastructure for old age homes and addressing needs of elderly persons
- Strengthening palliative and geriatric care
- Checking distress migration
- Addressing differential needs of women and children.

e) **Education and Healthcare:** Panchayats plays a vital role in enhancement of primary education and eradication of illiteracy and fulfilment of universalization of primary education. The Department of School Education and Literacy has launched the Samagra Shiksha – an Integrated Scheme for School Education as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme with effect from the year 2018-19. This programme subsumes the three erstwhile Centrally Sponsored Schemes of Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA), Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA) and Teacher Education (TE). The Intermediate Panchayats can play key roles. They can work with the District level unit of the scheme to develop an overall framer for action at the Block level and district level. Based on this the planning can be done. Wherever required, the BDP should include projects to fill the gaps, supplement or complement the initiatives of the scheme and GPDPs.

The Intermediate Panchayat should ensure better coordination between Gram Panchayats and Village Education Committees (VECs) in their respective areas to ensure community ownership to educational institutions as it functions as a part of the social system. The Panchayats should provide essential support during preparation of school development plan by VECs to ensure toilet and drinking water facilities in the school premises. The Intermediate Panchayat may also include support for infrastructure, scholarships and hostel facilities for needy students. They also need to supervise Mid-Day-Meal programme in their respective areas through Gram Panchayats at the village level.

The Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution makes it clear that in rural areas functions related to the provision of primary health care including hospitals and dispensaries may be the responsibility of the PRIs. The Intermediate Panchayat must ensure adequate provision for smooth functioning of essential healthcare centres including Sub-centres, Primary Health Centres (PHCs) and Community Health Centres (CHCs) in coordination with Health Department in the respective areas. The Intermediate Panchayat may include activities related to infrastructure support in the plans. This support may include opening of testing labs/diagnostic centres, hostel facilities for patients/relatives of patients near CHC and Sub-divisional hospitals, provision of community toilet, drinking water facilities in the hospital area and other necessary infrastructural support in collaboration with health department. The activities must be discussed with experts related to health care sectors before integrating in the plan. The Intermediate Panchayat should monitor and be informed about the basic healthcare situation in the respective area. The Intermediate Panchayat must maintain proper database of healthcare situation in their areas and ensure continuous development and upgradation of facilities.

- f) **Basic Services:** In its first report for 2020-21, Fifteenth Finance Commission has allocated total Rs. 60,750 crore to all the three tiers of the Panchayats with half of the funds tied to drinking water and sanitation and the balance to be utilized as per the local felt needs of the people and to create durable community assets and improve their functional viability. During planning basic services at the block level, the plan activities of other line departments should be integrated accordingly and issues related to sanitation, water supply, sewage, solid waste management, maintenance of road, footpaths, street lighting, community assets may be given adequate priority. These services are also be included in the 29 subjects listed in the Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution and Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) to be achieved by 2030.
- g) **Sanitation:** Open defecation was being practised in India particularly in rural areas. Approximately 60 per cent of the rural Indian population was used to open defecation that negatively impacted health and wellbeing of vulnerable groups including women and children. In that context on 2nd October 2014 Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM) was launched to eradicate open defecation and make India Open Defecation Free (ODF) by 2nd October 2019 to mark 150th birth Anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi. It was he who propagated the concept of cleanliness and said “Cleanliness is next to Godliness”. It was a Mission Mode Project to construct 90 million toilets in rural India at a projected cost of 1.96 lakh crore (US\$28 billion). The objectives of Swachh Bharat Mission (Gramin) included eliminating open-defecation through the construction of household-owned and community-owned toilets and establishing an accountable

mechanism of monitoring toilet use. Since the launch of the SBM, India's rural sanitation coverage increased from 39% in 2014 to 100 % on 2nd October 2019. The programme has achieved its objectives to make India Open Defecation Free in 2019.

The Government of India launched Swachh Bharat Mission – Gramin (SBM-G) Phase II with focus on Open Defecation Free Plus (ODF Plus), which includes ODF sustainability and Solid and Liquid Waste Management (SLWM). SBM (G) Phase-II is being implemented from 2020-21 to 2024-25 in a mission mode with a total outlay of Rs. 1,40,881 crores. This is a novel model of convergence between different verticals of financing. Of this Rs. 52,497 crores would be allocated from the budget of Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation while the remaining amount would be dovetailed from the funds being released under 15th Finance Commission, MGNREGS and revenue generation models particularly for solid and liquid waste management. The role of Intermediate Panchayat is critically important for successful implementation of the scheme as they are one of the key stakeholders for the grants under the recommendation of 15th Finance Commission and revenue generation models.

Intermediate Panchayat has to play an important role in providing sanitation in their area. Further, sanitation is one of the important focal area of Intermediate Panchayat and activities related to sanitation need to be incorporated in the Block Development Plan prominently.

- h) **Drinking Water:** Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) has been launched by the Government of India in partnership with States, to enable every household in villages to have Functional Household Tap Connection (FHTC) in the next five years with total estimated cost of Rs. 3.60 Lakh Crores. It is envisaged that with FHTC, each household will have potable water supply in adequate quantity of prescribed quality on regular and long-term basis. Under the mission Gram Panchayat and/ or its sub-committee has to plan, implement, manage, operate and maintain its in-village water supply systems. In fact the JJM is a flagship scheme of the government, which seeks to not only provide functional household tap connection for all, but also seeks to promote the holistic management of local water resources. In this scheme also the role of PRIs is very important for achieving the objectives of the scheme in convergence with the activities to be taken under the grants to Panchayats on the basis of the recommendation of 15th Finance Commission, MGNREGS etc. with the support from Panchayat. The mission is to provide every rural household with drinking water supply in adequate quantity of prescribed quality on regular and long-term basis at affordable service delivery charges leading to improvement in living standards of rural communities. The programme would implement source sustainability measures as mandatory elements, such as recharge and reuse through grey water

management, water conservation, rainwater harvesting etc. with community-based approach to water usage and conservation.

Important role of the Intermediate Panchayats include participation in Block Water and Sanitation Committee (BWSC) at block Level; in preparation of plan to provide drinking water supply, testing of water quality and monitoring of water supply to household level, and coordinate with Public Health Engineering Department for household supply of drinking water. Thus the Intermediate Panchayat need to plan for creation of sustainable infrastructure for supply of drinking water to people of the area.

7.7.9 Special Block Sabha and Involvement of Line Departments

A comprehensive Special Block Sabha should be organized after the collection of primary and secondary data, gap analysis, visioning, estimating resource envelop and identifying corresponding activities. In this Special Block Sabha, all developmental needs and gaps would be discussed. All SWGs would make presentation covering their proposed activities along with estimated budget requirement. Further, the representative of line departments would give a brief structured presentation regarding the activities of the department. The officers representing line departments are also to make public disclosure before the Block Sabha regarding progress of activities being implemented in the current year along with fund utilization for the same, as well as activities proposed to be taken up during next year (year in which the BDP is to be implemented) and funds to be allocated for the same. The representative of NRLM may also present their activities in the block and poverty reduction plan for the block. The public disclosure in the form of statement is to be submitted to the Intermediate Panchayat for incorporating in the Block Development Plan, once the same is approved by the Block Sabha. The nodal officer appointed shall also ensure community mobilization including vulnerable sections like SC/ST/Women during the Block Sabha. The IPPC would make presentation on Development Status Report and proposed activities with budget requirements before the Special Block Sabha, which would deliberate on the different presentations and give suggestion for the Block Development Plan.

7.7.10 Convergence with Schemes and Programmes of Line Departments

The Intermediate Panchayat implements many of the development activities through other line departments and there is a need to ensure that there is harmony and frequent interactions for effective implementation of schemes and programmes. Thus the Intermediate Panchayat prepares the plans with comprehensive perspective rather than isolated approach. Intermediate Panchayat should take the initiative by coordinating with these departments and agencies for convergence at the block level. This can be made possible

through joint situational analysis, planning and finally incorporating these activities in the Block Development Plan. In this context the plan preparation at the Intermediate Panchayat level assumes very high significance.

7.7.11 Project Development

After the consolidation of the prioritized activities the IPPC in consultation with SWGs, technical personnel of line departments, shall prepare a list of feasible and executable works. These works may be converted into form of projects. The projects can be extended to any subject and activity of the focus areas that improve the services delivery including education, health, social welfare and poverty reduction etc. All identified works may be mapped to match the resources available with the IP including funds relating to the Central and State Government schemes. Matching contributions from line departments, public and donors can be tried extensively. It is also necessary to clearly workout the output and outcome for all works. These activities may be prioritized for incorporation in the Block Development Plan.

7.7.12 Plan Preparation and Approval of Block Development Plan

The draft of the Intermediate Panchayat Plan shall be prepared after consolidation of the GPDP in the block, detailed deliberation in Special Block Sabha leading to the activities to be undertaken and project development by each SWG. The draft plan shall be prepared for the identified focus areas by IPPC incorporating projects prepared by their SWGs. The plan should contain sector wise plans and convergence with line departments. There is a need to ensure that the draft plan takes into account the availability of resources and ensure that plans for upliftment of marginalized and vulnerable groups belonging to all social classes are included. This would ensure sector based plan and convergence of related line departments. After finalizing the draft plan, it should be placed before Block Sabha for approval. Block Sabha would approve and adopt the integrated Block Development Plan as approved plan. During the meeting, a brief presentation on the Block Development Plan and project-wise details should be made and the proposed plan should be deliberated. During the process, the minutes of the meeting shall be recorded properly. The decisions taken during the Block Sabha must be displayed on the notice board in the office of the Intermediate Panchayat and the various other local institutions. Every Intermediate Panchayat will have a Public Information Board of size 10" × 20" at important public places and approved plan may be written on the Board schematically.

7.7.13 Plan Implementation

The implementation of the approved plan is the responsibility of the Intermediate Panchayat. There is a need to ensure that timelines are adhered strictly to ensure timely and effective implementation of the plan. There is also a need to put in place a mechanism for monitoring and supervision. The

implementation can be uploaded in the e-Gram SWARAJ portal and all payments shall be through the PFMS portal. The Intermediate Panchayat may take adequate care for completion of the activities within the specified time and avoid spill over of works as also put in place a mechanism to avoid deviation from the approved plans. It may also be ensured to create maximum livelihood opportunity to local people in the work being executed as part of implementation of the plan without compromising with the quality of the output and outcome.

7.7.14 Monitoring System, Course Correction and Modification of Block Development Plan

The Intermediate Panchayat needs to put in place a mechanism to ensure that the approved Block Development Plan is implemented, and the progress is constantly monitored. An extended monitoring and evaluation committee with representatives from diverse backgrounds and organisations may be constituted. The monthly meeting of the Intermediate Panchayat shall regularly review the progress and problems identified in the implementation of the plans shall be referred back to the IPPC and SWGs for further action. Representatives from different line departments, technical experts, members from SHG federations, experts from academic/technical institutions, representatives of the Intermediate Panchayat may be included for wider and detailed evaluation of the projects undertaken under the Block Development Plan. It is also desirable that specific mechanism should be put in place for community monitoring for ensuring transparency, participation, wider consultation and accountability. The IPPC on the advice of the SWGs should deliberate the problems encountered and suggest modifications to the approved Block Development Plan for getting the approval of modification, alteration and addition from the Intermediate Panchayat.

7.8 IMPLEMENTATION AND MONITORING OF BLOCK DEVELOPMENT PLANS

By and large all Gram Panchayats have acquired necessary skills and capacity in general with regard to preparation of Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP) of their respective area. However, this may not be the case with the Intermediate Panchayat (IP) and District Panchayat (DP) in many States. Apart from preparing the plans, it is also important to have an implementation mechanism supported by a comprehensive monitoring system. As we move up in the tiers of Panchayats, this becomes more complex. The following may be considered in the implementation and monitoring of the Block Development Plan (BDP):

- Mandating the use of PFMS for all releases and transactions of expenditure by the IP.
- Well defined mechanism to be put in place for implementation, which includes designated implementing officers for each development sector.

- Fund flow mechanism to be in place.
- Accounting and finance management system to be put in place
- Monitoring Plan preparation process as well as for implementation and follow-up.
- Strengthening the social audit mechanism with in-built quality control processes for the works/ activities of the Panchayats.
- Geo-tagging of all assets created with the funds and online display of the same in the portal.
- Correlating the outputs of the expenditure of the funds with the final outcome of factors related to standard of living of the citizens.
- Reviewing, monitoring and mentoring will be at State, district and block levels.

The Empowered Committee (EC) constituted at State Level for the GPDP to extend necessary support and issue clarifications would be the committee for the BDP. The EC has the powers to resolve all operational issues and to issue appropriate instructions and directions to all stakeholders. The EC may use district and intermediate level SDG target and indicator framework as a tool to map and monitor progress being made.

Coordination Committee at Block Level for Block Development Plan:

The State constitutes a Block level Coordination Committee with the Block Panchayat President/Block Development Officer or equivalent as chair with block level officials from line departments and selected GP Sarpanches as members. The committee would ensure inter-departmental coordination at the block level and implementation and monitoring of the BDP. They would also coordinate with the Coordination Committee at District level.

Community Based Monitoring: Monitoring of the BDP and DDP would be undertaken at various levels. There is the Empowered committee at the State level followed by District Coordination Committee and Block Level Coordination Committee. For individual project, the Sectoral Working Group excluding the implementation officer of the particular project can be given the responsibility of monitoring. However, Community Based monitoring becomes critical, both in the BDP and DDP. In case of the GPDP, community-based monitoring is less complex as it happens nearer to the people with direct people's participation. In case of the BDP and DDP, it becomes more complex. A community-based monitoring group may be formed to support the Block level and District level coordination committee comprising of representatives from stakeholder groups like SHG collectives, farmers' groups, entrepreneurs' group and academic institutions under Unnat Bharat Abhiyan. The community-based monitoring may be carried out in the following manner:

- Field monitoring by identified officers and Quality Monitors at State/district levels.
- IT based monitoring including geo-tagged, time stamped photographs of assets.
- System of pro-active disclosure may also be put in place, in appropriate formats.
- National Level Monitors (NLMs) for preparation and implementation of the BDP and DDP.
- Independent evaluation.
- Monthly Progress Reports (MPR) on physical progress, financial progress, and expected outcomes project (work) - wise need to be prepared by the IP and DP in the prescribed format and shared with supervisory authorities.
- Social Audits as a tool to ensure that the programme and the functionaries are accountable to the community.
- Monitoring of the relevant sectoral departments at the block, district and state levels.

Social Accountability for Block Development Plans: Social Accountability and Panchayats: Social accountability mechanisms contribute to improved governance, increased development effectiveness through better service delivery and citizen empowerment. There are many tools for ensuring social accountability including citizen charter, citizen report card, gender responsive budgeting, participatory planning, social audit, wall painting, Right to Information, public hearing, gender audit etc. All these may be used for the BDP. In addition, for enhancing social accountability the following may be ensured:

- The Block Sabha meetings should have participation of women and members of marginalized communities.
- All stakeholder meetings should have participation of women and members of marginalized communities.
- All Sectoral Working Groups should have participation of women and members of marginalized communities.
- All meetings should be documented. These recorded minutes and reports should be available in the Panchayat offices for public disclosures.
- All relevant documents used in the preparation of the BDP should be maintained and made available to the public.
- Public Information Boards should be present at every IP office, worksites and common places in villages with information on resource allocation,

progress on targets, monitoring and timelines of SDGs and Government schemes.

- Proactive disclosures through, wall paintings and applications such as PFMS for utilisation of the funds at the disposal of the Panchayats should be accessible to all.
- Regular conduct of Social and Gender Audit of the Panchayat activities and flagship programmes and schemes of government.
- Performance evaluations of Panchayats should be periodically conducted on developing and implementing gender responsive, participatory and socially inclusive Development Plans.

Social Audit for Block Development Plans: The process of Social Audit combines people's participation and monitoring with the requirements of the audit discipline. Since the agency, implementing the scheme cannot itself audit it; therefore, it is necessary to promote people's participation in the audit along with support provided by an independent social audit organization and civil society groups that facilitate the process. The Social Audit process is a fact-finding process and not a fault-finding one. For this, the Community Based Monitoring Group proposed earlier could be assigned to carry out the social audit. The process of Social Audit involves the following steps:

- To identify and understand the present state of the selected social programmes.
- To compare what is found with given norms in the operational guidelines.
- Verification of the findings by local community through public hearing.
- Verification of the findings by independent experts.
- Preparation of social audit report based on the findings.
- Mandatory validation of social audit report in Block Sabha.
- Public hearings of action taken report on public hearing decisions.
- Public display of action taken report in MIS and the IP office.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: a) Write your answer in the space provided below.

b) Compare your answer with the text.

1) What do you mean by block plan? Write in detail.

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7.9 BLOCK AND DISTRICT DEVELOPMENT PLANS THROUGH E-GRAM SWARAJ AND GIS

The Panchayats, being the initial interface of rural populace and governance/administrative structures, are the lowest rung of Government machinery that can induce mass ICT culture at the grassroots level. With a view to enabling large sections of rural population to benefit from new technologies that facilitate access and sharing of information and delivery of services, Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR) has formulated a scheme for Information and Communication Technology (ICT) enablement of all the Panchayats in the country in a Mission Mode approach. The Panchayats being the basic unit for planning and implementation of a large number of schemes and services, e-Panchayat programme would also go a long way in improving governance including public service delivery with better outcomes.

The 'centrality' of Panchayats in all development programmes of Government of India is now well accepted. e-Panchayat aims to completely transform the functioning of Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs), making them more transparent, accountable and effective as organs of decentralized self-governing institutions. With a vision to usher in digital Panchayats to empower and transform rural India, e-Gram SWARAJ (<https://egramswaraj.gov.in/>), a unified tool for effective monitoring and evaluation of works taken up in the Panchayats was launched by Hon'ble Prime Minister on National Panchayati Raj Day, on 24th April, 2020. The application improves reporting and tracking of Panchayat activities, providing a single interface for capturing Panchayat information.

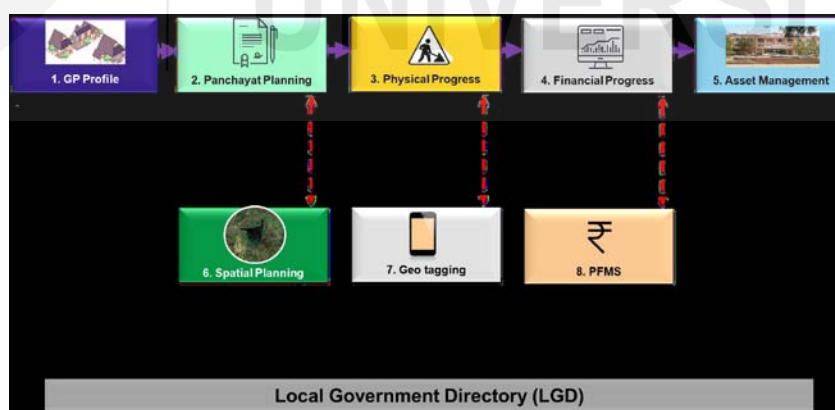


Fig. 7: Architecture of e-Gram SWARAJ

e-Gram SWARAJ application provides a Single window with the complete Profile of the Gram Panchayat, including Sarpanch and Panchayat Secretary details, Demographic details of the Panchayat, Details of Panchayat finances, asset details, activities taken up through Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP), Panchayat information from other Ministries/departments such as Census 2011, SECC data, Mission Antyodaya survey report etc.

The (e-Gram SWARAJ) application strengthens and decentralizes planning process so that the development funds consumed by the Plans result in effective outcomes.

Block and District Development Plans through e-Gram SWARAJ: The Planning Workflow begins with suggestions/need/ expectations expressed by citizens in Gram Sabhas/Ward Sabhas. Each Gram Panchayat identifies activities or incorporates a suggestion and can assign it to a work. Mission Antyodaya (MA) survey would provide the baseline data for the Plan preparation at all the three tiers of the Panchayats. Once the activities are identified, the Gram Panchayat would carry out a yearly exercise of preparing the Gram Plan Development Plan (GPDP). The exercise would involve listing all the activities that are supposed to be taken up in the financial year, prioritizing these works, link the activities taken up in GPDP with the gaps identified in the MA survey and identifying various resources (schemes) to fund these activities. e-Gram SWARAJ Planning Module would enable intelligent convergence of funds from different schemes for the activity, thereby ensuring on the one hand that the available funds are utilized to the maximum possible extent, and on the other hand that important activities are not left out/ abandoned for lack of funds.

Higher level Panchayats have the advantages of scale which enables them to more efficiently undertake certain activities as compared to the Panchayats below them. Therefore, the Intermediate Panchayats should have a clear visibility of the plans of Gram Panchayats. The Gram Panchayats (GPDP) need to consider the approved plans of Gram Panchayats and Intermediate Panchayats (GPDP, BDP) before finalizing their plans. Therefore, a system of 'Vertical Integration' would be put in place.

The Intermediate Panchayat would review GPDPs to identify those activities that would be better implemented if entrusted to the Intermediate Panchayat and Include them in the Block Development Plan (BDP)

Once the District/Intermediate Panchayat has finalized the list of proposed activities before fund allocation from different schemes, they can forward the plan for Technical Appraisal. The system will automatically route the plan to Technical Appraisal Group (TAG) users for scrutiny. TAG would scrutinize the plan, give their comment and could send back the plan to the Planning Unit (Panchayat) for Review or if all works are approved the plan is automatically routed for administrative approval.

GIS Support for Planning and Implementation of Block Development Plans

GIS (Geographical Information System) based tools essentially consisting of design and creation of spatial as well as attribute databases and integration of the same to facilitate the creation of various planning scenarios for facility planning and management, integrated with the priority and needs of the people, ensuring basic facilities, avenues for livelihood, and productive use of

resources could be leveraged. Gram Man Chitra application developed by Ministry of Panchayati Raj (MoPR) could be utilized for accessing various integrated geospatial layers derived from space-based inputs vis-a-vis Area Profile Report Generation, Asset Mapping, Activity Planning and Implementation-Monitoring for facilitating effective developmental planning.

Gram Manchitra would provide an opportunity to view the GIS maps (Village Panchayat Map/ Block Panchayat Map/ District Panchayat Map) on various parameters of Health, Education, and Population etc. This option will be helpful to view the developmental profile and plan for the unit accordingly. GIS can help the Intermediate Panchayat in deciding which activity to be taken in which area for addressing the need of the area.

GIS can enhance transparency in planning, implementation and operation. It provides ‘real time’ monitoring of activities and implementation status.

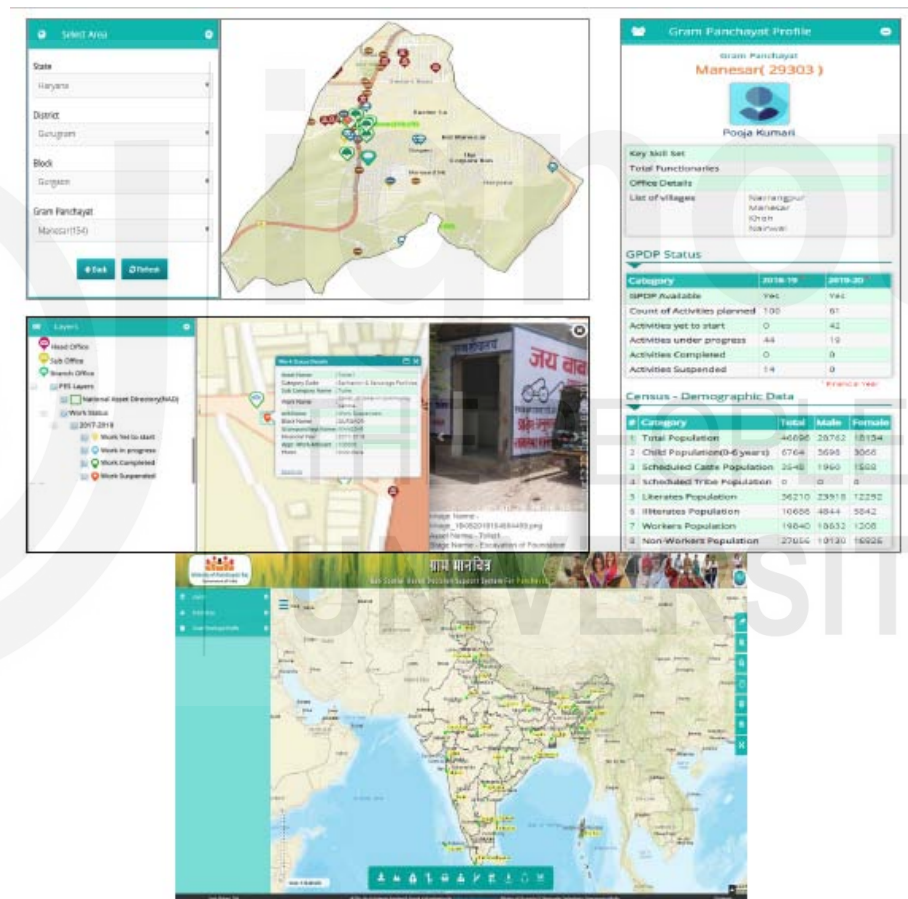


Fig. 8: Screenshot of Gram Manchitra

- Geo-tagging/geo-referencing the location from where data is being collected thereby enhancing the reliability of data when plotted on the base map to enable a “granular” analysis at the disaggregated level.
- Identification of suitable site for creation of new amenities.
- Visualization of all approved works with their attributes for the plan on the map.
- Visualization of spatial trends in Panchayats plan implementation such as:

- Focus area wise activities being implemented in a Panchayat.
 - Comparison between Physical progress vs. financial expenditure for activities underway in a Panchayat etc.
 - Fund utilisation trending.
- v) Management of Assets and infrastructure like roads, Schools, hand Pumps etc.
- vi) Decision Support system to check and monitor the activities at different level. It can help for facilitating better and efficient planning.
- Land Holding Analysis
 - Health Services Analysis
 - Social Strata and Eligibility Analysis
 - Education Analysis
 - Available Financial Amenities Analysis.
- vii) Natural Resource management
- Agricultural land Spread
 - Wasteland
 - Watershed
 - Groundwater Potential
 - Water Resource Management Plan.

7.10 LET US SUM UP

The Block Level Planning is lower than the District Level Planning but higher than the Local or Panchayat Level Planning. This level of planning was started right in the First Five Year Plan. For planning purposes, each district was divided into a number of blocks. Each block consisted of about 100 villages and a population of about 60,000. Participation of the local people is very important and decisions by the local people are intended to use the local resources in a better way. The 73rd Amendment defines the levels of Panchayati raj institution into three viz. District level, Intermediate level (Block level) and Base level (village Panchayat). The second level of planning is executed by the samiti of the villagers. The general supervision of blocks is done by Block Samitis under the chairmanship of the Block Pramukh and elected representatives.

The primary aim of the Block Level Planning is to understand the problems of the local people, to find ways and means to solve those problems and formulate as well as execute the developmental plans. Proper understanding of the local problems helps in optimum utilisation of the local resources. It generates employment opportunities and the way for planning. In fact the entire strategy of the Block Level Planning is based on employment planning, growth centre planning and credit planning.

The main activities of this type of planning include the following:

- a) Agriculture and allied activities,
- b) Soil conservation and water management,
- c) Animal husbandry and poultry,
- d) Fisheries,
- e) Forestry,
- f) Processing of agricultural produce,
- g) Organising input supply, credit and marketing,
- h) Cottage and small scale industries,
- i) Local infrastructure,
- j) Social services (drinking water supply, health and nutrition, education, housing, sanitation, local transport and welfare programme) and
- k) Training of local youth and updating of skills of local population.
- l) Disaster Management.

7.11 KEYWORDS

Decentralization: The transfer of control of an activity or organization to several local offices or authorities rather than one single one.

NREGA: Mahatma Gandhi Employment Guarantee Act 2005 (or, NREGA No 42, later renamed as the “Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act” or MGNREGA), is an Indian labour law and social security measure that aims to guarantee the ‘right to work’.

Bottom-up Approach: A **bottom-up** approach is the piecing together of systems to give rise to more complex systems. It is a type of information processing based on incoming data from the environment to form a perception.

7.12 SUGGESTED READINGS

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UNIT 8 VILLAGE LEVEL PLANNING

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- 8.1 Aims and Objectives
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8.1 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

This unit aims to draw your attention to the significance and procedure of village level planning in rural development. In this unit, you will be able to understand:

- Process of planning at local level;
- Role of 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act in village level planning;
- Two-tier system and tribal plan;
- Process of village level planning; and
- Critically assess village level planning.

8.2 INTRODUCTION

In the previous unit, you have learnt about the planning at Block level. In this unit, you will learn about planning at village level. Under the system of rural democratic decentralization- popularly termed as Panchayati Raj, the rural people elect village Panchayat members who are responsible for executing the plans and programmes for rural development. Through this system the process of planning comes down even further from the Block level to the lowest level of rural governance, i.e., village. A planning process at **first** stage begins with identification of problem through analysis of present

situation and preliminary look at possible future opportunities. At **second** stage goals and objectives are set; at **third** stage, alternative ways/ means for achieving goals and objectives are looked into; at **fourth** stage, the planners select appropriate plan to accomplish goals; at stage **five**, the plan is implemented by the planners on the ground; at stage **six**, evaluation of the plan is carried out to check the progress and what has been achieved and at **final** stage, the planners compile the record of the decisions taken at each stage in the form of summary of the planning used to achieve goals for future development. Proper planning leads to better results delivered on time in a cost-effective manner with the end result being the achievement of the overall objectives in the most effective way. Participation is one of the most effective tools in planning which enables people to work together with a spirit of collaboration and cooperation. Thus, they make decisions about the development, ensuring reflection of the priorities and interests of all major groups in planning and their commitment to translate planning into action. In the implementation of policies, citizens' participation can generate trust, credibility and commitment (Brody et al., 2003). Conflicts are resolved during the planning process rather than delaying the implementation of completed plans in participatory democracy (Moote et al. 1997). It is a common practice that the knowledge of centralized planning in India goes back to pre-Independence period whereas local planning is a recent experience during the post-Independence period. Let us begin with significance and background of the planning at local level in India.

8.3 PLANNING AT LOCAL LEVEL

Keeping in mind that rural development bears a special significance to India's development, a lot of planning and programme initiatives have been taken for rural development, e.g. agricultural growth, employment of rural youth, water supply, infrastructure development, housing, health and education. Planners at the higher level would formulate programmes and schemes for the development of rural areas without being fully aware of the ground realities. In the post-Independence period, systematic efforts were made from time to time for the overall development of rural areas. Community Development Programme (CDP) was launched in the first five-year plan period. Agricultural development was one of the core issues of CDP. People's participation through certain grassroots level institutions like the block level institutions, village panchayats, Gram Sabhas, Mahila mandals, youth clubs, Krishi Charcha Mandals, etc. were tried. But these village level planning institutions were largely voluntary, without any statutory back-up. A vast sum of money was spent on rural development through different departments in order to reach the rural people directly. Several new programmes and schemes were launched every now and then without paying any attention to the ground realities and needs and priorities of the rural masses. Weak planning capabilities at the block level and absence of effective village based institutions for people's participation compounded

the problems of village level planning. In this approach of ‘planning from above’, the target group remained mere passive receivers of the programmes and services. This shortsightedness was reflected in the implementation of these programmes and schemes, as they couldn’t yield the desired results.

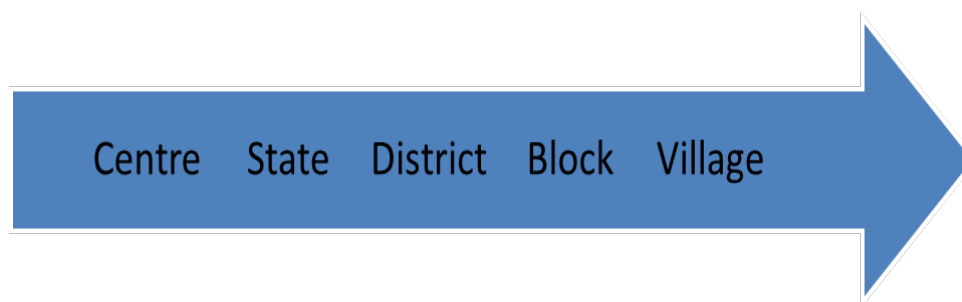


Fig. 1: Planning is done at the top and information and resources are passed on to the lower levels

Hence, there was a need for involvement of rural people in the planning process for the development of their own community. With the view to removing the lacunae in the planning and implementation of policy and programmes for rural masses, there was a paradigm shift in social planning. Instead of ‘planning from top’, focus was on ‘planning from below’, which is the inherent theme of village level planning. Village level planning ensures participation of those who are the final targets of developmental planning. Village level planning is the form of planning at the lowest institutional level of the village where the people from all sections of the society get together and enlist and prioritize the areas of intervention; take a view of their resources and formulate, execute and supervise the plans for the development of their own community by sharing responsibilities among themselves. Figure 2 shows the planning process and flow of resources and information in the village level planning.

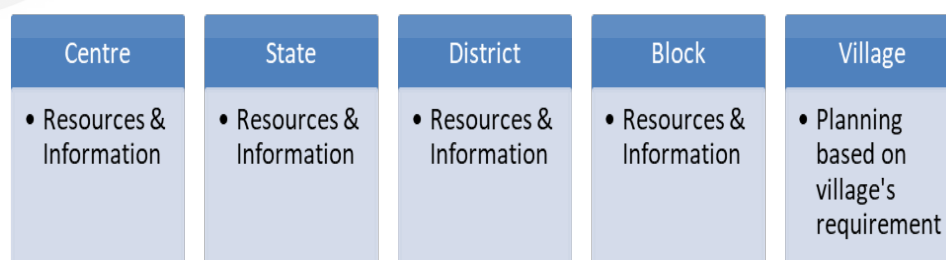


Fig. 2: Decentralization of Powers

The decentralization of powers from Centre to States, States to districts, and areas within districts and villages can be one of the best ways of radically restructuring an over-centralized system of planning. Centralization has made the common people over-dependent and apathetic towards the government programmes which are meant for their own welfare and development. On the contrary decentralization results in empowering people, promoting public participation and increasing efficiency. Under the system of democratic

decentralization that is called Panchayati Raj in the context of rural areas. Rural people elect village Panchayat members who are responsible for executing the plans and programmes for rural development. The village members participate in the planning of rural development programmes and its monitoring, supervision and evaluation through Gram Sabhas. One of the unique features of this democratic decentralization is involvement of all sections of the society in the planning and execution process. The weaker sections of the society, who have, more or less, never been involved in decision-making process for community development, are given the legal right to be part of the village level planning. The scheduled castes, scheduled tribes, other backward classes and women have been given due reservation of seats in various wards and constituencies. The inherent theme behind the involvement of representatives of weaker sections has been to secure the well-being of their respective fellow people. In the same manner, women are expected to raise issues related to the welfare and well-being of females during planning process in Panchayat. In the village level planning, the village Panchayat deals with many issues pertaining to rural development like regulating building construction, protection of public lands against encroachment, maintenance of traditional drinking water sources, collection and disposal of solid waste and regulation of liquid waste disposal, maintenance of environmental hygiene, management of public markets, vector control, protection of roads and other public properties, street lighting and its maintenance, adoption of immunization programmes, agriculture related activities like cultivating waste lands and marginal lands, soil protection, encouraging horticulture and vegetable cultivation and management of Krishi-Bhavans. The scope of village level planning is too vast. It also includes other crucial areas like animal husbandry and dairy farming, minor irrigation, fishing, social forestry, small scale industries, rural housing, water supply, electricity and energy, education, public works, public health and sanitation, social welfare, poverty alleviation, development and welfare of scheduled castes and scheduled tribes, promotion of sports and cultural affairs, public distribution system, relief work during natural calamities, etc. Apart from all these areas of intervention, it is the duty of the Panchayat to ensure people's participation in all the activities for the development of the village and to maintain transparency in their work.

Thus, it may be implied that decentralization has been seen as necessary as well as desirable for the participation of the people in the process of planned development. With the 73rd Constitutional Amendment of 1992, Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRI) and urban local bodies have taken their roots all over the country. Though teething problems are natural, the success stories of PRIs functioning have been reported, more or less, across the length and breadth of the country. Let us discuss the role of Panchayati Raj in village level planning in little more detail.

8.4 THE PANCHAYATI RAJ SYSTEM AND VILLAGE LEVEL PLANNING

The matters relating to decentralized planning are gaining wide interest among the social planners and researchers. It is universally agreed that 'local problems have local solutions' and a blanket strategy cannot be effective even within a district. A brief look at the institutions of democratic decentralization will help in understanding its significance. Community Development Programmes were introduced in 1952 in order to transform the social and economic life of the rural community. These programmes could not elicit effective people's participation. To understand the reasons, Balvantrai Mehta Committee was set up, which recommended institutionalization of local participation and democratic decentralization through Panchayati Raj system. It suggested three-tier system of Panchayats: Zilla Parishad at the district level, Block Samiti at the intermediate level and Village Panchayat at the lowest level.

Many states adopted the recommendations of the committee but the Panchayati Raj system in these states was not uniform. There were feelings of general apathy or indifference or even hostility among the officials and state level politicians. Powers of the Panchayat members were very limited. The institution itself could be dissolved by the district authorities. Elections for Panchayats were very irregular. Consequently Panchayati Raj started fading away after 1965. From 1977 to 1988, many committees and sub-committees were set up to look into the institution, its strengths and weaknesses and to suggest modalities to make it effective. Committees like Ashok Mehta Committee (1977), GVK Rao Committee (1985), LM Singhvi Committee (1986), PK Thungan (1988) and VN Gadgil (1989) studied various aspects of the Panchayati Raj institutions and came up with valuable suggestions, though they differed with each other in proposed modalities and structure of the Panchayati Raj. Among others, the salient recommendations made by these committees included constitutional recognition to Panchayati Raj bodies with three-tier system, fixed term of five years and reservations for SCs/STs and women. Subsequently, the 73rd Amendment Act, 1992 that came into effect from 24 April 1993, provided Constitutional sanction to the powers, responsibilities and finances of the Panchayat bodies.

A fundamental change that has occurred in Indian polity is that the democratic base of the Indian polity has widened. Prior to the Amendment, Indian democratic structure of elected representatives was restricted to the two Houses of Parliament, 28 State Assemblies and two assemblies of Union Territories. Now, there are nearly 630 District Panchayats, about 6614 block/tehsil/mandal Panchayats at the intermediate level and about 253,268 Gram/village Panchayats in the country. As a result of this structural change, in every five years, about 31 lakh representatives are elected by the people, of whom 13.75 lakh are women (MoPR, 2019).

Even though the Panchayati Raj institutions existed before this landmark constitutional amendment, they had neither real power to take decisions, nor did they have any financial or legal powers to execute their plans. This Act ensures provision of rights and responsibilities to the elected members of the Panchayat to play a much larger role in the development. Now, the Panchayat bodies are empowered institutions executing regulatory, administrative and developmental functions. This act entrusts the village Panchayat to plan and execute programmes on subjects like agriculture, land improvement, animal husbandry, small scale industries, safe drinking water, health and sanitation, poverty alleviation programmes, family welfare, social welfare and the like. Before understanding how village level planning is done, let us understand the basic features of the existing Panchayati Raj.

8.4.1 Salient Features of Panchayati Raj

It is a three-tier structure of local self governance where, at the village level, Village Panchayat takes care of the civic and developmental administration. Block level body or Block Panchayats assists Village Panchayats and gives technical advice and guidance for execution of developmental programmes. Here, it may be noted that smaller states with population below 20 lakhs will have the option of not to have the intermediate level Panchayat. At the district level, Zilla Parishad is mainly supervisory and coordinating institution and functions as a bridge between state and people below district.

One of the mandatory provisions that shapes the structure of the new PR administration is the establishment of Gram Sabha or 'village assembly', which comprises all adult members registered as voters in the Panchayat area. Gram Sabha is the basic unit of the democratic system. Every adult citizen of that area can take part in the village level planning through the Gram Sabha. The Gram Sabha has the right to take part in the planning, supervision of the activities and financial status of the programmes being implemented in its respective area. The village Panchayat is accountable to Gram Sabha for all its activities. Gram Sabha acts as a watchdog over the functioning of lower-level Panchayat. All the states have provided for the constitution of Gram Sabha but in terms of meetings there are variations among the states ranging from once in a year in Madhya Pradesh and West Bengal to four times in a year in Assam. Some states like Tamil Nadu and Karnataka have integrated Gram Sabha into the process of selecting the beneficiaries that make them more active in the process of development. It also makes the process of selection of beneficiaries, in many developmental programmes, more transparent.

The present constitutional amendment Act ensures to fulfill, both, structurally and financially the responsibilities of the PRIs, through reservations for the backward sections including women and other backward castes. This has enabled these sections to occupy seats of decision-making. Due recognition has been given to the citizens belonging to weaker sections like women, SCs/STs and OBCs to take active part in the functioning of the PRIs. Seats

and posts of chairpersons of the Panchayats at all levels are reserved for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) in proportion to their population in that area. One-third of these must be women. As a result, women are chairpersons of about 200 district Panchayats, more than 2000 Block/Tehsil/Mandal Panchayats at the intermediate level and about 85,000 Gram Panchayats. Also, there are about 700,000 elected members belonging to the SCs/ STs categories. A large number of hitherto excluded groups and communities are now included in the decision-making bodies.

Another important feature of Panchayati Raj institution is that seats at all levels are to be filled by direct election. The tenure of the panchayat bodies is of five years. Election of members to constitute a new Panchayat is to be completed before the expiry of the term. In the event of dissolution, elections should be held compulsorily within six months. Also, for each state, an independent Election Commission has been constituted for superintendence, direction and control of the electoral process. Direct elections make the members of the Panchayats at all levels directly accountable to their respective constituency, resulting in greater pressure to perform effectively for village development.

In 2015, the Fourteenth Finance Commission grants were devolved to GPs that provided them with an enormous opportunity to plan for their development on their own. Since then, local bodies, across the country are expected to prepare context-specific, need-based Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GPDP). Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP) brings together both the citizens and their elected representatives in the decentralized planning processes. GPDP is expected to reflect the development issues, perceived needs and priorities of the community, including that of the marginalized sections.

8.5 TWO-TIER SYSTEM: TRIBAL PLAN

Tribal societies are often known for their unique life-style, customary laws and socio-cultural mores. They are not homogeneous groups in terms of their demographic, social, economic and educational aspects. Some communities among them are numerically very small, while the others are large. Some communities are socially and economically vulnerable. Many tribal societies have been living autonomously, cut off from the rest of the society. These groups have their own vibrant institutions of administration. They need to be given due attention to their indigenous institutions and ethos while considering democratic decentralization in tribal areas.

Integration of traditional tribal Panchayats with the PRIs is necessary to consider the manner in which these could be integrated with the bigger structure of the statutory PRIs without disturbing them in any way. A committee was set up, known as Bhuria Committee, to make recommendations to extend the Panchayats to the Scheduled areas. Its aim

was to provide a suitable administrative framework for self-rule or grassroots governance with traditional management practices to safeguard and preserve the traditions and customs of tribal society. As per the recommendations made by the Bhuria Committee a Bill was passed in the Parliament in 1996 that is known as 'The Provisions of the Panchayats (Extension to the Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996. Let us now pay attention to some salient features of the extended Act.

Any legislation on the Panchayats for the tribal areas shall be in consonance with the customary law, social and religious practices and traditional management practices of the community resources. It intends to keep their integrity and identity intact.

Unlike the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, even small, scattered tribal settlements have been declared as a village for the purpose of the enactment of the extended Act. In tribal areas, with mostly hilly topography, the villages are small and scattered by their population. The 1992 Act considers these small hamlets or *tolas* as village with their own Gram Sabha. It is a very significant feature of the extended Act. It protects the theme of democratic decentralization and village level planning. The combination of more than one village, just for the number's sake, would have resulted in domination of the larger communities over the smaller ones.

Gram Sabha is the nucleus of democratic decentralization and village level planning. According to the extended Act, every member, whose name has been included in the electoral list of that village, is the member of the Gram Sabha. These village assemblies or Gram Sabhas have been endowed with wide ranging powers and functions for empowering them to safeguard and preserve the traditions, customs and cultural identity of the people, community resources and settling local disputes through customary methods. The Gram Sabha takes part in the planning process for socio-economic development of the tribal community. It has the power to approve or reject the plans and programmes developed by village Panchayat for the socio-economic development of the community. The Gram Sabha also identifies and selects beneficiaries for poverty alleviation and other programmes. For all the projects and programmes for socio-economic development of the village, the villages Panchayats are supposed to obtain a certificate of utilization of funds from the Gram Sabha. So, it is seen that people's participation has been institutionalized in a proper way through this Act where the common tribal people actively participate in the planning and implementation of policies and programmes for the development of their community.

The tribal people are often victims of so-called 'developmental projects' like construction of dams and roadways. Many a times, in the past, they have been displaced from their environment and rehabilitation was at the mercy of the authorities. However, this extended Act provides the power to the tribal people to take decisions on topics affecting and influencing their life directly

or indirectly. According to the Act, the acquisition of land for development projects and rehabilitation or resettlement of persons affected by such projects in the scheduled area has to be done in consultation with Gram Sabha or village Panchayats at appropriate level. Planning and implementation of the projects is coordinated at the state level. Similarly, grant of prospecting license of mining lease and grant of concession for the exploitation of minor minerals by auction has to be given on recommendations of Gram Sabha or the Panchayats at the appropriate level.

It is generally seen that tribal areas are rich in minerals, forest and water resources. Traditionally, the tribal people have been using these natural resources which have not only economic value for them but also the socio-cultural and religious connotations attached to them. Recognizing that tribal communities should retain command over these natural and economic resources, powers for planning and management of minor water resources in these areas and granting license for mining or leasing out minor minerals have been vested with Panchayats at the appropriate tier. This would reduce illegal mining or over exploitation of natural and economic resources, to a great extent.

The extended Act takes into account the persistent problems of tribal people, such as growing indebtedness, land alienation, forest related problems, problems of displacement, alcohol, water and other natural resources. It has been mandated that either the Gram Sabha or the Panchayats at the appropriate level have to be consulted before the acquisition of land in these areas. Similarly, while rehabilitating the persons displaced from such projects, these bodies shall be consulted, so that resettlement is realistic, viable and acceptable to the affected families.

Besides the above-mentioned functions and powers, the Gram Sabha or the Panchayats at the appropriate level shall have the following mandatory powers:

- a) To enforce prohibition or to regulate or restrict the sale and consumption of any intoxicants.
- b) To have the ownership of minor forest produce and to manage all types of village markets.
- c) To prevent alienation of land and to take appropriate action to restore any unlawfully alienated land of a Scheduled Tribe in the scheduled areas.
- d) To exercise control over money-lending to tribals and to control institutions and functionaries working in the social sectors in the area.
- e) To exercise control over local plans and its resources including tribal sub-plans.

Another important aspect of this Act is the affirmative action in favour of the tribal people. Reservations of seats at all tiers of Panchayats for the Scheduled Tribes shall be less than one half of the total number of seats and reservation for other communities shall be in the proportion to the population of these communities. Also, the chairperson of all levels of Panchayats shall be reserved for the Scheduled Tribes. At the intermediate or district level Panchayats, in the case of scheduled tribes which have no representation, the state government shall nominate such unrepresented Scheduled Tribes, but such nominations should not exceed one-tenth of the total elected members in the Panchayat. The implicit objective behind this provision is that tribal leaders have a better opportunity to express the specific needs and problems of their own community and they can secure the well-being of their fellow people.

The powers and authority have been given to the Panchayats and the Gram Sabha to enable them to function as institutions of self-government. Due attention has been paid to the fact that Panchayats at the village level planning should have enough power to plan and implement policies and projects for the socio-economic development of their tribal community. Panchayat bodies at the higher level should assume the role of facilitators and advisors to the village Panchayats. It is likely to restrict the misuse of power by the political leadership or bureaucracy in the implementation and management of developmental plans and programmes. It would also bring in transparency and accountability in the system and will lead to closer monitoring by the people. Let us now discuss the process of village level planning. Before this let me check your progress.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: i) Write your answer in the space provided below.

ii) Check your answers by reading the text once again.

1) Discuss the role of Panchayati Raj in village level planning?

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2) Discuss the role of two-tier system of tribal panchayats in village level planning?

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- 3) What is Gram Sabha? Discuss the role of Gram Sabha in village planning?

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8.6 PROCESS OF VILLAGE LEVEL PLANNING

It is an approach to bring the planning process closer to the people so that they can decide their developmental priorities and participate in the planning and implementation. The PR system provides an institutional framework in which the community people play major role in their own development. Village level planning, also, known as micro-level planning, is a technique, which helps in identifying developmental needs of the community people, prioritizing them and formulating viable projects, so as to realize maximum development with limited resources within a stipulated time period. The major responsibility of village level planning, more or less, lies with the village Panchayat.

Prior to 73rd Constitutional amendment also, the village Panchayats had the responsibility to initiate and implement the developmental tasks in their respective areas. However, actual implementation of need-based developmental activities could not be done by the village Panchayats effectively, as they were not provided with necessary administrative authority and resources to fulfill the responsibilities. Under the 73rd Constitution Amendment Act, the village Panchayats have been provided with both the requisite authority and the necessary financial resources to carry out the plans and programmes needed for the welfare and development of their respective village communities.

Before the Panchayati Raj came into effect as constitutional institution, almost all the developmental functions in the village were carried out by the government machinery. As a result, the village Panchayats were playing a secondary role with practically no opportunity for the village people to participate in it. This has created a 'dependency syndrome' where people looked towards the government for every administrative, welfare and/or developmental activity. They would have no say in the matters that directly or indirectly influence their lives as well as that of their community. This led to the situation in which the government officials developed a feeling that they are the masters and could dictate the terms to the people as to what was needed by them and what was good for them. These circumstances have continued for decades. Now, it is a challenge to reverse the situation in which people are motivated to take the role of decision-makers. The government

machinery should be there as helping hand. The key aspect of village level planning is people's participation in their own development through local self-governance.

There are certain necessary pre-requisites for the PRIs to function as institutions of self-governance. There should be clearly demarcated areas of jurisdiction with adequate powers and authority commensurate with responsibilities. There should be necessary human and financial resources to execute the plans effectively. The PRIs at all the three layers should be given the functional autonomy within the federal structure. The Constitutional Amendment Act of 1992 seems to create opportunities for fulfilling these conditions, so as to execute their responsibility of rural development effectively. To understand the village level planning let us begin with a look at major tasks or activities that the Panchayat bodies are entitled to perform in the planning.

8.6.1 Major Areas of Village Level Planning

According to the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, there are 29 items, covering different aspects of socio-economic life of the villages such as regulatory functions to maintain civic amenities, social service and infrastructure, development and enhancement of economic resources of the village and welfare and development of weaker sections, particularly the families below the poverty line. The 29 items transferred to PR institutions can be grouped into seven major sectors as follows:

Sector 1: Agriculture and Allied Activities

- 1) Agriculture and extension
- 2) Land improvement, land reforms, consolidation, soil and water conservation
- 3) Minor irrigation
- 4) Animal husbandry, dairy, poultry, etc.
- 5) Fisheries.

Sector 2: Forestry and Environment

- 6) Social and farm forestry
- 7) Fuel and fodder
- 8) Minor forest products
- 9) Non-conventional energy resources.

Sector 3: Industries

- 10) Small industries including food processing
- 11) Khadi village and cottage industries.

Sector 4: Infrastructure, Minimum Needs, Social Services

- 12) Roads, culverts, bridges, ferries, etc.

- 13) Rural electrification
- 14) Drinking water
- 15) Rural housing
- 16) Education
- 17) Technical and vocational education
- 18) Adult and non-formal education
- 19) Libraries
- 20) Cultural activities, festivals, etc.
- 21) Health, sanitation, etc.
- 22) Family welfare
- 23) Public distribution system
- 24) Markets and fairs.

Sector 5: Social Welfare

- 25) Women and child welfare
- 26) Social welfare including welfare of handicapped and mentally retarded
- 27) Social welfare of scheduled castes and scheduled tribes.

Sector 6: Poverty Alleviation Sector 7: Maintenance of Community Assets

Planning for these 29 items at the three levels of the PR system would be difficult unless the constituent components of various levels are segregated and allocated powers at the appropriate level of the three-tier PR system. Here, it may be mentioned that many States have their respective Panchayati Raj Act that distinctly mentions distribution of the item-related activities among the three tiers of Panchayat bodies. This has helped in dividing the responsibilities between the three tiers in respect of planning and implementation with a clear demarcation of authority, resource sharing and also specifying the role of official hierarchy in each line department. The 29 items can be divided into as many as 290 activities of which 108 are district components, 87 block components and 95 village components.

The eventual focus of the decentralized planning is village development. The village level planning or micro-level planning, as a tool for development of villages, will be effective only if there is clarity of the items that fall within the purview of the Village Panchayat, Block Panchayat and District Panchayat. Clarity of their respective roles, interdependence in implementation of plans and programmes among themselves and with the government machinery, the technical and managerial expertise available to them from the government departments, and the adequacy of financial support from various sources is also necessary. For example, in the case of agriculture and allied sector, seed production can be the role of district Panchayat; seed, fertilizer and pesticide storage that of Block Panchayat; and the village Panchayat may be responsible for the distribution of seeds, fertilizers and pesticides.

8.6.2 Gram Panchayat Development Plan

This is the recent development in the context of Panchayati Raj under which Gram Panchayats have been mandated for the preparation of Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP) for economic development and social justice utilizing the resources available to them. GPDP planning process has to be comprehensive and based on participatory process which involves the full convergence with Schemes of all related Central Ministries/Line Departments related to 29 subjects enlisted in the Eleventh Schedule of the Constitution. Panchayats have a significant role to play in the effective and efficient implementation of flagship schemes on subjects of National Importance for transformation of rural India.

8.6.3 Financing Village Development Plans

The proper execution of village development plans depends on the financial resources available with the village Panchayat. There are three types of activities for which finances are required by the village Panchayat. **First**, it is maintenance of Panchayat office that includes salary of the office bearers, maintaining office building, electricity, water, furniture and other office materials. **Second** set of activities is related to maintenance of civic services, physical infrastructure and Panchayat assets. **Third**, investment is required for the construction of new infrastructure and developmental activities including poverty alleviation and social welfare programmes. According to the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, a Finance Commission is to be constituted in each State to determine the principles, on the basis of which adequate financial resources are ensured for Panchayats.

Now let us look into the sources of income for the village Panchayat. A large portion of the finances comes in the form of state grants through many programmes like Jawahar Rojgar Yojna. Besides, the village Panchayats have the right to develop self-reliance by collecting taxes such as house tax, property tax, cattle tax, etc. and the costs of civic services provided to the community to meet the maintenance expenditure. However, as a number of families are poor and not in a position to pay the actual cost of the services, they could be asked to pay a lower rate for a certain period and till that time, the state should compensate to the Gram/village Panchayats.

8.6.4 Monitoring and Supervision of the Developmental Works

Panchayat Samiti and Zilla Parishad can also depute official and non-official functionaries to monitor the developmental activities of the village Panchayats and advise them where corrective measures are required. However, the prime role of social auditing and supervision and evaluation lies with the Gram Sabha.

Gram Sabha has been assigned a key role for the effective functioning of Panchayats. Based on the need-assessment of the community, Gram Sabha

decides what developmental work is to be undertaken by Gram Panchayat on priority basis. Gram Sabhas can also question and scrutinize the decisions of Panchayats in their meetings and discuss the annual financial statements of Gram Panchayats. Under the Act, the Gram Sabha itself has been vested with a wide range of powers including ownership of minor forest produce, approval of developmental plans, selection of beneficiaries under various programmes, management of minor water bodies, control of mineral leases, management of village markets and regulation/prohibition of sale of intoxicants.

Gram Sabha has been given the task to perform one of the most important roles of social audit at a time when the corruption at all levels of administration is often thought to be rampant. This social auditing is expected to be done by the Gram Sabha members. This makes the members of the village Panchayat directly answerable to the voters, unlike the distant legislator. In order to introduce public accountability, the Gram Sabha's role of social auditing should be given due importance. The completion of the works should be approved by the Gram Sabha and only after that, the utilization certificate should be granted by the authorities concerned. Without Gram Sabha's approval, the completion certificate issued by the government departments should not be treated as valid.

8.6.5 Modalities of Grassroots Level Planning

After knowing the areas as well as the participation involved in the process of village level planning, let us view 'how' of the planning process occurs. The village Panchayat members hold their meetings regularly, frequency of which is clearly mentioned in the respective states' Panchayati Raj Acts. It differs from State to State which is on an average once a month. In a village Panchayat meeting, which is held either in Panchayat Bhavan or at any common place in the village, the quorum of two-third of the members is required. The members of the village Panchayat share responsibilities for planning and executing various developmental works (as mentioned in 29 items) among themselves in the form of various sub-committees as per the rules and regulations specified in the PR Acts of their respective states. Panchayat meetings have a formal structure where, usually, the president or Sarpanch chairs the meetings and decisions on issues related to the working of Panchayats are taken by majority. Similar modalities are followed at the block as well as district levels.

Further, Gram Sabha meetings, on an average, are held at least once in three months (frequency differs from state to state). The quorum of the Gram Sabha shall be 10 per cent of the number of voters of its area. In case, the quorum for Gram Sabha is not complete, the meeting is called again. This time, the quorum should be 50 people when convened again (it also differs state-wise). In the meeting of Gram Sabha, resolutions are passed on majority basis. Role of Gram Sabha is indeed very important. It assists in preparing developmental schemes for the village and supervises the implementation of such schemes.

Gram Sabha has the power to supervise activities of village Panchayat. It evaluates the progress of the developmental programmes in the village. The village Panchayat should place a report of progress of the existing and the proposed projects in front of Gram Sabha. This village assembly of voters scrutinizes the expenditure undertaken during the current year and the proposed one. It checks the annual statement of accounts and the administration report of the preceding year. If, in any circumstances any decision of the Gram Sabha could not be implemented, the president or Sarpanch shall report the reason for it in front of the Gram Sabha. The village Panchayats, the Block Panchayats and the District Panchayats shall give due consideration to the suggestions of the Gram Sabha, as mentioned in the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act. The Gram Sabha may appoint, elect or constitute general or special sub-committees for a detailed discussion on any issue or programme and for effective implementation of the schemes and its decisions in furtherance of its rights and responsibilities.

8.7 GRASSROOTS LEVEL PLANNING: A CRITICAL VIEW

The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act is a historical landmark in the democratic decentralized village level planning in rural India. However, changes in the social system and more so in social structure come at their own pace. The new Panchayati Raj system is also gaining ground in various states with initial teething problems. Let us pay attention to some of the challenges that are faced in the process of democratic decentralization and village level planning.

Although PRIs have ensured women's participation in the decision-making, their involvement, in some cases, is restricted to 'tokenism'. Their family members generally take all the decisions that they are entitled. Most often, rural women have been found to be lacking initiative even in sounding the needs and problems that they face in their community. A qualitative change in their level of participation is essential. There is a pressing need to train the women leaders in Panchayati Raj system about their rights and responsibilities as elected members.

Reservations, even in the case of SCs, STs and backward classes, have ensured mere representation in these local institutions but no sincere effort to promote capacity-building is seen whereas it is a prime need at the Gram Panchayat level. The elected members belonging to SCs/STs/OBCs are unable to actively participate in the deliberations. Serious awareness and training is required so as to realize the purpose of affirmative action for these previously deprived groups in the community.

Almost all the rural development programmes, which are planned and implemented at the village level, do not enjoy any flexibility in terms of tuning them to the specific needs of the villages, as they are governed by the

Central/States guidelines, thus, leaving little scope for accommodating the choice/preference/priority of the village people. For example, in the case of Jawahar RojgarYojna (JRY), in which the financial resources are directly transferred to the village Panchayats to carry out various types of works for employment generation, the authority for technical and financial approval is vested with block and district level officers. Thus, in many programmes where the village Panchayats have been given responsibility for implementation they do not possess the powers of sanctioning the works and money without the concurrence of the bureaucracy.

Another major problem with Centre/State-sponsored development programmes is that all the activities are planned and executed within the financial year and, thus, there is adhocism in the planning. This does not provide any scope for preparing a perspective plan for village development.

In actual practice, the state level MPs and MLAs are articulating their constituency priorities in Zilla Panchayat meetings and are, thus, interfering with the development programmes implemented in the area. By and large, these state and national level legislators are given local area development fund of approximately Rs. 50 lakhs to Rs. one crore annually. With the amount, they do not seem to visualize any legislative role with regard to their respective constituencies. Under these circumstances, they try to stall the process of financial devolution to these local institutions, thus, hampering economic development.

Besides these factors, the role of PRIs at different levels with respect to planning and implementation of the 29 items transferred to them remains vague. To overcome these problems the various components of the 29 items should be segregated and allocated to different levels of PRIs. In order to make clear distinction between the roles and responsibilities with respect to various components at the three levels; namely, district components, block components and village components.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: i) Write your answer in the space provided below.

ii) Check your answers by reading the text once again.

1) What is the process of village level planning?

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- 2) Discuss the modalities of village level planning under the Panchayati Raj.

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- 3) Make a critical assessment of village level planning under the Panchayati Raj.

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8.8 LET US SUM UP

Planning is the process of deciding an activity in organized way to make it happen in effective and successful manner. Having proper planning means effective management which leads to better results delivered on time in a cost effective manner with the end-result being the achievement of the overall objectives in the most effective way. Decentralization has been seen as necessary and desirable for participation of people in the process of planned development. With the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments of 1993, Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRI) and urban local bodies respectively have taken root all over India. Panchayati Raj is a three-tier structure of local self-governance where, at the village level, Village Panchayat takes care of civic and developmental administration. Block level body or Block Panchayat assists Village Panchayats and give technical advice and guidance for execution of developmental programmes. One of the mandatory provisions that shape the structure of the new Panchayati Raj administration is the establishment of Gram Sabha comprising all the voters in a village. Gram Sabha is the basic unit of the democratic system. Every adult citizen of that area can take part in the village level planning through the Gram Sabha. The Gram Sabha has the right to take part in planning, supervision of the activities and financial status of the programmes being implemented in its respective area. The village Panchayat is accountable to Gram Sabha for all its activities. Gram Sabha acts as a watchdog over the functioning of lower level Panchayat. The present constitutional amendment ensures to fulfill, both structurally and financially, the responsibilities of the PRIs, through reservations for the oppressed sections, including women and other backward castes. This has enabled these sections to occupy seats of decision-making. Integration of traditional tribal Panchayats with the PRIs is necessary to consider the manner in which the traditional tribal Panchayats could be integrated with the bigger structure of the statutory PRIs without disturbing them in any way. A Bill was passed in the Parliament in 1996, which is called 'The Provisions of the Panchayats (Extension to the Scheduled Areas)

Act, 1996. The PR system provides an institutional framework in which the community people play major role in their own development. Village level planning, also known as micro-level planning, is a technique, which helps in identifying developmental needs of the community people, prioritizing them and formulating viable projects, so that with limited resources maximum development could be achieved in a stipulated time. The major responsibility of village level planning, more or less, lies with the village Panchayat.

8.9 KEY WORDS

Village Level Planning: The form of planning at the lowest institutional level, i.e., village under the Panchayati Raj in India

Panchayati Raj: A three-tier system of people's participation institutionalized through Panchayat formed of elected members at district, block and village levels in rural India.

Gram Sabha: A General Assembly consisted of all the adults of a village entitled to participate actively in the planning for their own community and to ensure accountability and transparency.

8.10 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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